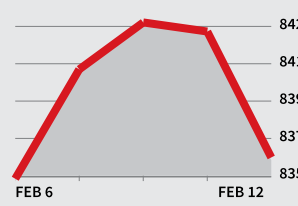


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 83674.92 (-558.72)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	25807.20	-146.65
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	22.96	-0.20
US Dollar (in ₹)	90.59	-0.11
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	155027.00	-1665
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	259133.00	-7316

NO CHEER IN THE CUPPA.

Prices of arabica coffee are down 20%, while robusta eased only marginally since last November, in line with global markets **p12**



TALENT REBALANCE.

Falling overseas student numbers and visa uncertainty are driving professionals to India-first careers **p14**

BENGALURU - CHENNAI - COIMBATORE - HUBBALLI - HYDERABAD - KOCHI - KOLKATA - MADURAI - MALAPPURAM - MANGALURU - MUMBAI - NOIDA - THIRUVANANTHAPURAM - TIRUCHIRAPALLI - VIJAYAWADA - VISAKHAPATNAM

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QUICKLY.

VOLUME GROWS

HUL Q3 net dips 30% on labour code spend



Mumbai: Hindustan Unilever reported a 5.7 per cent rise in Q3 FY26 revenue driven by 4 per cent underlying volume growth amid demand recovery. However, the net profit (from continuing operations) fell 30 per cent due to the new labour codes and higher overall expenses. The FMCG major reported a net profit of ₹2,118 crore on a consolidated revenue of ₹16,441 crore. **p2**

US TEXTILE RELIEF

‘India to get tariff parity with Bangladesh’

New Delhi: Indian textile exporters will receive parity with their Bangladeshi counterparts in the US market, with zero reciprocal tariffs subject to raw material-sourcing norms, Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal said. Though the move buoyed garment makers, it sparked concerns among Indian farmers over a potential influx of US cotton. **p3**

DAC clears ₹3.25 lakh crore deal for 114 Rafale fighter jets

AIR POWER. Announcement expected during French President Macron’s India visit

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

The ₹3.25 lakh crore deal to acquire 114 Rafale fighter aircraft from France’s Dassault Aviation, set to be India’s biggest-ever defence purchase, advanced to its next stage on Thursday after the Defence Acquisition Council (DAC) cleared it ahead of French President Emmanuel Macron’s visit to India from February 17.

In this government-to-government deal, a majority of the multi-role fighter aircraft (MRFA) Rafale will be “manufactured in India,” said the Defence Ministry. Besides the Rafales, the DAC, headed by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, cleared various other proposals valued at ₹3.60 lakh crore.

Sources said following the DAC’s grant of acceptance of necessity (AoN) to the Indian Air Force’s proposal, the project will move into the formal contract negotiation stage.

This will lead to the issuance of a request for proposal (RFP), which will firm up the overall cost, scope of



LOCAL PUSH. In this government-to-government deal, a majority of the multi-role fighter aircraft Rafale will be “manufactured in India,” said the Defence Ministry

technology transfer, manufacturing terms in India, and the division between aircraft to be delivered in flyaway condition and those to be produced domestically.

HUNT FOR INDIAN PARTNER

Dassault Aviation is also scouting for an Indian partner for local manufacture of the fighter jets, which are expected to be integrated with indigenous weapon systems and radar technologies.

But before that, the IAF proposal has to get another set of approvals from the Cabinet Committee on Security, headed by Prime Min-

ister Narendra Modi. Though there may be some announcement relating to the deal during Macron’s visit, the wrapping up of the contractual process is expected to get stretched towards the latter half of this year, sources said.

The IAF already has 36 Rafales, while the Navy signed a contract last year to get another 26 marine versions of the aircraft at a cost of ₹63,000 crore.

If this deal goes through, the IAF will become the second largest operator of Rafale after France, which has 225 aircraft in its fleet.

The DAC also green-

lighted procurement of Scalp combat cruise missiles, also from France, to replenish existing Rafale jets’ weapon inventory.

BUY FOR NAVY

It also cleared the purchase of 6 P8I long range maritime reconnaissance aircraft from the US to take the fleet strength to 18.

“The acquisition of P8I aircraft, per the Defence Ministry, will significantly boost the Navy’s long-range anti-submarine warfare capability, maritime surveillance and strike capability,” the statement read.

The DAC also cleared an IAF proposal to induct airship based high altitude pseudo satellites (AS-HAPS) — drones or balloons for intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance (ISR) missions.

The committee also approved the induction of four MW marine gas turbine-based electric power generators under the Make-I category of the Defence Acquisition Procedure 2020, aimed at boosting the Navy’s self-reliance in power generation.

Info-tech stocks tumble on AI disruption fears

Madhu Balaji
Bengaluru

Info-tech stocks came under heavy selling pressure on Thursday, tracking losses of Wall Street peers, amid rising concerns over the impact of artificial intelligence (AI)-led disruption on software services earnings.

The Nifty IT Index slumped 4.8 per cent to 33,408.15 from its previous close of 35,095.15, with all constituents trading in the red.

Investors fear advanced AI models could automate several traditional IT services, reshaping demand for outsourcing and weighing on future growth.

Stocks of majors including Infosys, TCS, Wipro, Coforge, Tech Mahindra and HCL Tech led the decline. Infosys fell 6 per cent to ₹1,386, while TCS dropped 5.49 per cent to ₹2,750.10 after hitting a 52-week low. Wipro closed below its 52-week low.

Despite the IT rout, the broader market was relatively resilient, with the Sensex and Nifty declining 0.66 per cent and 0.57 per cent, respectively. The Nifty IT Index is now down over 13 per cent year-to-date.

Details p6

Jan retail inflation at 2.75% under new CPI base year

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

The retail inflation under the revised Consumer Price Index (CPI) series stood at 2.75 per cent in January, the first reading with a new base year of 2024, the Statistics Ministry said on Wednesday.

The updated series aims to better reflect current household spending patterns.

Officials cautioned that the January print is not directly comparable with December’s 1.33 per cent inflation rate with 2012-base year.

BASE YEAR AT 2024

The revised series updates the consumption basket to align with current expenditure trends. Chief Economic Advisor V Anantha Nageswaran said the overhaul will strengthen the data foundation for policy decisions.

“Since the CPI basket is now aligned with recent expenditure data, the inflation signals derived from this will more closely match economic conditions. This improves the information basis for calibrating monetary and fiscal policy,” he said.

Under the new series, food inflation in January was 2.13 per cent, while housing infla-

Coverage in retail inflation

	2012 series	2024 series
Rural markets	1,181	1,465
Urban markets	1,114	1,395
Online markets	NIL	12
Towns	310	434
Items (weighted)	299	358
Goods	259	308
Services	40	50

Source : MoSPI

tion came in at 2.05 per cent.

Price pressures were uneven across categories. Garlic, onion, potato, arhar/tur dal and peas saw the lowest inflation rates, while silver jewellery, tomato, coconut and copra, gold and diamond jewellery, platinum jewellery, and coconut oil registered the sharpest increases.

SPENDING PATTERNS

Nageswaran said the re-weighting captures structural changes in household consumption as incomes rise.

“At the macro level, this reflects a progressive diversification of expenditure towards health, education, mobility and connectivity — typical of an economy witnessing rising incomes and living standards,” he said.

Also read p7

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QUICKLY.

Bharat Forge posts strong growth in Q3



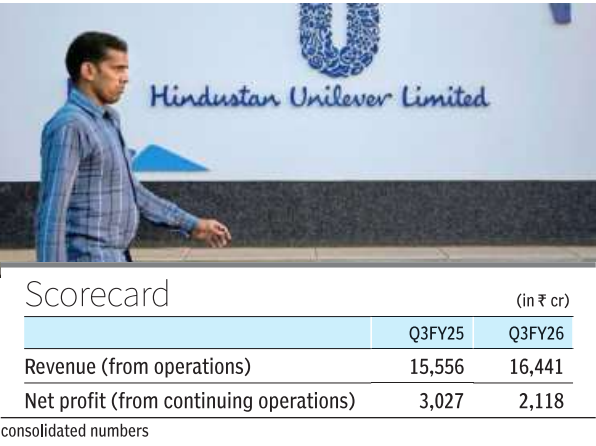
Pune: Bharat Forge Ltd (BFL) on Thursday reported strong sequential growth for the quarter ended December 31, 2025, led by a robust performance in the domestic automotive business and execution of its defence order book, even as de-stocking in the North American commercial vehicle (CV) market continued to weigh on overall performance. On a standalone basis, revenue rose 7 per cent quarter-on-quarter to ₹2,084 crore, while EBITDA increased 4.6 per cent to ₹569 crore. The EBITDA margin stood at 27.3 per cent, down 70 basis points sequentially due to product mix and tariff costs. Profit before tax (before exceptional items) grew 2.7 per cent on-quarter to ₹443 crore, and profit after tax (PAT) came in at ₹288 crore. Export revenues declined 3 per cent sequentially. **OUR BUREAU**

HUL revenue for Q3 rises 5.7% to ₹16,441 cr on demand recovery

NET DECLINE. However, profit fell 30% due to new labour codes, higher overall expenses

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Hindustan Unilever reported a 5.7 per cent rise in Q3 FY26 revenue driven by 4 per cent underlying volume growth amid demand recovery. However, net profit (from continuing operations) fell 30 per cent due to the new labour codes and higher overall expenses. The maker of Dove and Lux soaps reported a net profit of ₹2,118 crore on a consolidated revenue of ₹16,441 crore. Excluding the wage impact, net profit saw a 1 per cent growth. Overall consumer sentiment had perked up and there was an improvement in demand, said CEO & Managing Director Priya Nair in a media briefing. “Bigger improvement is in rural, and rural continues to outperform urban,” she added. Growth in the quarter was led by the premium portfolio in personal care, beauty & wellbeing and strong delivery in laundry liquids. India, alongside US, was a



key contributor to the overall momentum, and clear anchor markets for parent Unilever Plc, CEO Fernando Fernandez said. The Indian FMCG bellwether will continue to prioritise volume-led growth, with premiumisation remaining as a key focus. Performance in FY27 is expected to be better than in the current fiscal year. CFO Niranjana Gupta said the operating environment should support a sustained recovery in consumption. “Our broad-based growth in the current quarter reflects gradual momentum across our portfolio. Coupled with positive, conducive consumption environment, we expect growth in FY27 to be better than FY26,” he said. Growth remains our number one priority. We will continue to invest in the business as needed to support sustained growth and we expect EBITDA margins to stay around the current guided range, he said.

EBITDA margin shrank 70 bps in the quarter to 23.3 per cent.

QUICK COMMERCE The company is doubling down on its investments in quick commerce, its fastest growing channel contributing 3 per cent to total revenue. It has set up a dedicated organisation and deployed advanced supply chain capabilities to build a bespoke operating model that will enable it to lead the growth. “This is not just an investment in people but it is also an investment in technology, systems and processes,” Nair said. As part of its strategy of focusing on fewer and bigger bets HUL announced acquiring the balance 49 per cent stake in Zwyte Ventures for ₹824 crore, while divesting its minority stake of 19.8 per cent in Nutritionalab for ₹307 crore. With the demerger of the ice-cream business completed, Kwality Walls will be listed on the Indian exchanges on February 17.

States’ devolution at 39% lags 41% recommendation of finance panel

Sourashis Banerjee
Chennai

The recently tabled Sixteenth Finance Commission (FC-16) report has renewed focus on how India shares tax revenues between the Centre and the States. Data compiled from the FC-16 report and Union Budget trends show while States’ devolution is gradually increasing, it still falls short of the spirit of higher fiscal empowerment implied in past commission debates.

DATA FOCUS.

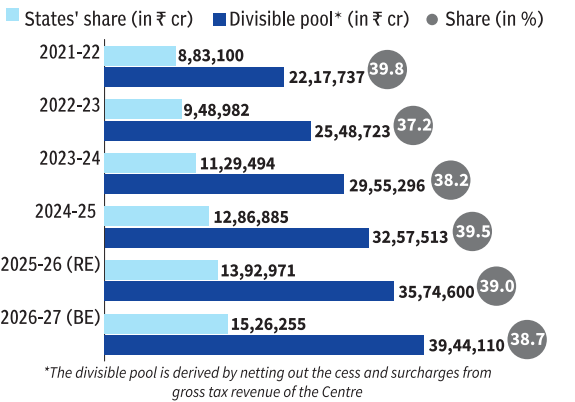
Between 2021-22 and 2026-27 (BE), the States’ share from the divisible pool of gross tax revenue (GTR) in absolute terms rose from about ₹8.83 lakh crore to ₹15.26 lakh crore. However, a *businessline* analysis shows the ratio of the share fell from around 39.8 per cent of the divisible pool in 2021-22 to 38.7 per cent in 2026-27, lower than the recommended 41 per cent. The divisible pool of the Centre’s GTR, that is available to the States for devolution, is derived by subtracting cess and surcharges, and taxes accruing to the Union Territories from the GTR. The States’ devolution as a share of GTR (including cesses and surcharges) as given by the FC-16, increased slightly from around 32.6 per cent in 2021-22 to 34.7 per cent in 2026-27 (BE). Over three decades, the share climbed from roughly 25 per cent in 1991-92 to above 32 per cent in 2021-22.

CENTRE FALLS SHORT

The FC-16 records competing fiscal arguments from the Union and the States. The Centre argued that “significant increases in vertical devolution recommended by the FC-7 and FC-14 were premised on providing the States with more untied resources. The increased untied transfers aim to strengthen the fiscal autonomy of the States, but this has not always translated into sustained fiscal prudence on their part.” Further emphasising its own spending pressures, the Centre “calls for moderation in tax devolution because it requires additional resources for defence modern-

Devolution of States’ share

From divisible pool around 39 per cent



Budgeted cess reduces in FY27



Higher devolution to States with higher population

Share of big States			
States	FC 14	FC 15	FC 16
Uttar Pradesh	18.0	17.9	17.6
Bihar	9.7	10.1	10.0
Madhya Pradesh	7.6	7.9	7.4
West Bengal	7.3	7.5	7.2
Maharashtra	5.5	6.3	6.4
Rajasthan	5.5	6.0	6.4
Odisha	4.6	4.5	4.4

Source: 16th Finance Commission (FC) Report, Union Budgets

isation and prudent macroeconomic management.”

On the other hand, “States argue that the Constitution has assigned a proportionately larger expenditure responsibility to States. To discharge these responsibilities, they need more resources.” A majority of the States “highlighted the declining share of the divisible pool in the gross tax revenues of the Union and proposed measures to counter this trend. The measures included (i) inclusion of cesses and surcharges in the divisible pool; (ii) capping their share as a percentage of gross tax revenue and transferring any amount above that cap to the divisible pool; and (iii) compensatory enhancement of States’ share in the divisible pool if these levies remain excluded.” “As regards cesses and surcharges, the Union states that their exclusion from the divisible pool is by Constitutional design. The Union fur-

ther argues that though not shareable, cesses often fund welfare and infrastructure schemes that benefit the States.”

THE NUMBERS

Incidentally, the total of cess and surcharges reduced in 2025-26 and 2026-27 due to rate rationalisations by the Centre, reducing GST compensation cess to the States from ₹1.5 lakh crore in 2024-25 to ₹88,000 crore in 2025-26, and doing away with the compensation cess completely in Budget 2026-27. Meanwhile, horizontal allocation continues to prioritise equity and population-linked criteria, historically assigning large weights to demographic size and income distance to equalise public service access across States. This disproportionately benefits populous states, such as Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Madhya Pradesh, which continue to command the largest shares.

Hindalco Q3 net down 45% post US plant mishap

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Hindalco Industries, an Aditya Birla Group company, reported a 45 per cent fall in December quarter net profit at ₹2,049 crore against ₹3,735 crore logged in the same period last year, largely due to the one-time provision on account of fire accident at its US subsidiary, Novelis plant. Revenue was up 14 per cent at ₹66,521 crore (₹58,390 crore). EBITDA increased 5 per cent to ₹8,543 crore (₹8,108 crore). The company in-

curred an exceptional loss of ₹2,610 crore in the quarter under review.

\$50 M INSURANCE

It has already infused \$750 million as equity in Novelis and will pump in another \$250 million in this quarter to mitigate the impact of the fire accidents. The company has received \$50 million from insurance companies as compensation for fire at the Oswego plant and expects recovery soon. Satish Pai, Managing Director, Hindalco Industries, said Novelis’ underlying performance remains strong despite short-term capacity

Q3 results

	Q3 FY25	Q3 FY26
Revenue (₹ cr)	58,390	66,521
Net profit (₹ cr)	3,735	2,049
EPS (Diluted) (₹)	16.79	9.21

constraints from the Oswego disruptions. The 6-lakh tonne Bay Minette project is on track for commissioning in the second half of FY27, he said. Novelis reported an EBITDA of \$495 million and this should go up to \$600 million once the Bay Minette goes on stream, he added.

“In India, we have entered the next phase of growth with a clear roadmap to expand upstream capacities across alumina, aluminium and copper with aluminium capacity planned to scale up from 1.3 mt to 1.7 mt and copper smelting capacity from 4 lt to 7 lt,” said Pai. Hindalco Industries will spend ₹10,000 crore in FY26 and expects the capex to be around ₹10,000-12,000 crore in India. Revenue from aluminium upstream was up 6 per cent at ₹10,620 crore while EBITDA increased 14 per cent to ₹4,832 crore driven by better realisation.

EBITDA per tonne was up 6 per cent at \$1,572. Revenue of downstream aluminium was up 22 per cent at ₹3,909 crore with an EBITDA at ₹233 crore, up 55 per cent on account of higher shipments and favourable product mix. EBITDA per tonne at \$241 was up 35 per cent. Copper revenue was up 33 per cent at ₹18,233 crore due to higher prices and strong demand. EBITDA was down 23 per cent at ₹595 crore (₹777 crore) due to weak demand for copper continuous cast rod on back of higher LME and higher channel inventories.

Rolls-Royce to scale up in India

Our Bureau
New Delhi



A day after Rolls-Royce CEO Tufan Erginbilgic met Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the UK-based major engineering company announced its decision to scale up businesses in India by exploring potential co-development of a next-gen combat jet engine, and finding partnerships to localise and manufacture engines for the Indian Army, Navy and Coast Guard. As India advances its next generation military capabilities, Rolls-Royce with the UK Government, has offered to co-develop a 120 kN class combat jet engine core that could be India’s fastest route to an indigenous next-generation engine, it said in a statement to media on Thursday. The co-development will

provide full technology transfer with IP ownership for India, supported by a dedicated design complex and manufacturing capabilities that will unlock significant job creation.

POWER SOLUTIONS

Besides, Rolls-Royce is also looking up to offer power solutions for critical infrastructure and industry. These initiatives could more than double the size of the workforce that supports Rolls-Royce and its partners, to approximately 10,000 people in India, the state-

ment read. Rolls-Royce believes the opportunities it looks to secure could lead to a 10-fold increase in the company’s supply chain sourcing from India, a move which would nurture and benefit many small and medium sized enterprises (SMEs).

VIKSIT BHARAT

Rolls-Royce said Erginbilgic met with Modi to discuss the company’s desire to be part of Viksit Bharat and how its advanced technologies can support India’s growth plans and *aatmanirbhar* journey in critical sectors. Erginbilgic said, “Our ambitions for India are built on the strong foundations of our decades-long presence in the country, our growing footprint, our deep industry partnerships, and our competitively advantaged technologies.”

IHCL Q3 net up 55% at ₹903 crore on strong biz

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

Indian Hotels Company Ltd’s (IHCL) Q3 FY26 consolidated net profit grew 55 per cent on-year to ₹903 crore on the back of a strong business performance and exceptional gain from the sale of stake in a joint venture. Excluding tax and exceptional gain of ₹276 crore, consolidated net profit grew by 11 per cent. While IHCL’s performance in the first two quarters of the current fiscal were affected by the impact of Operation Sindoor, flight cancellations, high rainfall and landslides, there were no headwinds in Q3. Revenue grew 12 per cent on-year to ₹2,900 crore, driven by leisure travel and events. Earn-

ings before interest tax, depreciation, and amortisation rose 11 per cent to ₹1,134 crore. The company’s hotel segment reported its best ever quarterly EBITDA of ₹1,000 crore, it said.

239 SIGNINGS

“IHCL continued its growth momentum in FY26 with 239 signings to reach a portfolio of 617 hotels, and opened and on-boarded 120 hotels, led by strategic partnerships and acquisitions,” the company’s CEO and Managing Director, Puneet Chhatwal, said in a statement. The company expects strong growth to continue and expects the performance in Q4 of FY26 to be better than the same period last year, benefitting from multiple high-profile events and weddings.

Eicher gets nod for Cheyyar plant expansion; Royal Enfield capacity to rise to 20 lakh units

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

Eicher Motors Ltd has secured environment clearance (EC) for the ₹1,104 crore brownfield expansion of its Cheyyar manufacturing facility in Tamil Nadu where Royal Enfield motorcycles are produced. While the company’s pro-

posal submitted to the State government for EC states the investment as ₹1,104 crore, a company release showed the amount as ₹958 crore. The proposed expansion is for the construction of industrial buildings (factory building, vehicle assembly, machine shop, engine assembly, fabrication and surface finishing and plating).

Meanwhile, the company on Tuesday said its board had approved capacity expansion for Royal Enfield, which will be achieved through a brownfield expansion at the Cheyyar manufacturing facility in Tamil Nadu. Through the expansion, the annual production capacity will be increased up to 20 lakh units from the existing



The company will invest around ₹958 crore for brownfield expansion **BIJAY GHOSH**

14.6 lakh units. The company is set to invest an estimated ₹958 crore for the brownfield expansion, the company said in a regulatory filing.

B Govindarajan, Managing Director, Eicher Motors, and Chief Executive Officer, Royal Enfield, said this investment will augment the annual production capacity and allow the company to meet the existing and projected future demand. By scaling up the existing Cheyyar plant, the company is ensuring a faster capacity ramp-up and cost-efficient operations.

ALL-WOMEN PLANT

In June 2025, *businessline* reported that Royal Enfield’s Cheyyar two-wheeler plant will be an all-women plant. In August 2024, the company had a soft launch of the plant and currently is engaged in plating and auto buffing of parts.

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

The sale of 79 per cent stake for a consideration of ₹1,583 crore in Wellbeing Nutrition to pharma major USV is not a founder exit but a strategic partnership to scale within a pharmaceutical ecosystem, Avnish Chhabria, Founder and CEO of Wellbeing Nutrition, said. “This is not us cashing out but an entrance into a world that traditionally did not take nutraceutical brands seriously,” Chhabria said. “I continue to hold 15 per cent, and we remain fully committed to scaling Wellbeing,” Chhabria said. The other 6 per cent is held by Saurabh Kapoor, Co-

founder, and ESOPs. With this, Mumbai-based USV will expand its presence in the nutraceutical and consumer wellness space. The company has been in the oral anti-diabetic and cardiovascular segments, for over 60 years now, with brands including Glycomet GP, Ecosprin and Roseday, besides being the exclusive partner for the Sebamed range in India. The latest transaction will see USV add Wellbeing Nutrition’s portfolio, even as it plans for the GLP-1 therapy segment, as patents expire on semaglutide, for example. The acquisition expands its portfolio into preventive and lifestyle-focused healthcare. Wellbeing, founded in



Avnish Chhabria, Founder and CEO, Wellbeing Nutrition

2019, expects to close FY26 with revenue of about ₹263 crore, up from ₹112 crore in the previous year. The company is targeting ₹450 crore next year. Nearly 15 per cent of its revenue comes from prescriptions and hospital channels- largely uncommon in the largely D2C-driven nutraceutical market. The company has invested over ₹60

crore in research and development, building proprietary formats such as oral thin strips and delayed-release capsules. Chhabria said the company is unit-economics positive and expects to turn fully profitable over the next year.

PREMIUM SEGMENT

Wellbeing Nutrition operates in the premium segment with an average order value of around ₹2,500 and follows an omnichannel strategy spanning D2C, pharmacies and modern trade. It is present in over 6,500 retail outlets across India and has begun expanding internationally in the West Asia and Europe.

With inputs from Mumbai bureau

businessline.

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Indian textile exporters will get same tariff benefits in the US as Bangladesh: Piyush Goyal

MIXED REACTION. While garment exporters cheer, some farmers express concern about cotton sourcing requirements from the US

Amiti Sen
Prabhudutta Mishra
New Delhi

Indian textile exporters will get the same benefits as their Bangladeshi competitors in the US market and be allowed to export at zero reciprocal tariffs subject to raw-material sourcing requirements, Commerce & Industry Minister Piyush Goyal has said.

While the move has cheered garment manufacturers, who feared losing ground after Bangladesh secured its quota-based duty-free deal with the US, it has sparked concern among Indian farmers over the potential influx of American cotton.

“Just as Bangladesh has a facility that if raw material is

purchased from America, process it and make cloth and export it, then it will be available at zero reciprocal tariff, India also has the same facility and India will also get it. At the moment, India and the US have a framework agreement. When it will be finalised into interim agreement, you can see this in the fine print,” Goyal told reporters on Thursday.

Per the Bangladesh-US joint statement issued earlier this week, Washington committed to establish a mechanism that will allow for certain textile and apparel goods from Bangladesh to receive a zero reciprocal tariff rate. “This mechanism will provide that a to-be-specified volume of apparel and textile imports from Bangladesh can enter the US at this reduced tariff rate, but

At the moment, India and the US have a framework agreement. When it will be finalised into interim agreement, you can see this in the fine print

PIYUSH GOYAL
Commerce & Industry Minister



dia’s monsoon-sown cotton production is 29.22 million bales in 2025-26, marginally lower than 29.72 million in the previous year. The government had allowed import of cotton at zero duty until December 31 to augment domestic supplies, leading to a significant uptick in arrivals.

FARMERS’ CONCERNS
Some Indian farmers are apprehensive about what the deal will finally entail. “We want more transparency in the negotiations. While the textile industry knows what is happening, we are kept in the dark. A large number of Indian cotton farmers will be impacted adversely if import of US cotton is eased,” said Kannaiyan Subramaniam, President, Thalavady Farmers Association.

The US is trying to

“snatch” India’s cotton market from India, said Rampal Jat, National President, Kisan Mahapanchayat.

“It is essential to determine accountability for the failure to adopt an appropriate policy in this trade agreement in a timely manner,” Jat said.

While the US has fixed reciprocal tariffs of 18 per cent on Indian goods (to be soon brought down from 25 per cent), the reciprocal tariffs on Bangladeshi goods are at 19 per cent, down from 20 per cent after the revised deal. The MFN tariffs (regular tariffs applicable on all countries) on garments in the US is around 16 per cent, which will likely be applicable on exports from both Bangladesh and India, irrespective of the level of reciprocal tariffs.

‘Revised US factsheet reflects joint understanding on Ind-US trade framework’

Our Bureau
New Delhi



Randhir Jaiswal,
MEA Spokesperson

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) stated that amendments to a US factsheet regarding the India-US interim trade framework now reflect the shared understanding of the agreement. MEA Spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal emphasised that the original joint statement, issued on February 7, remains the definitive basis for mutual understanding. The clarification follows a period of diplomatic recalibration after Washington issued a factsheet on February 9 that appeared to go beyond the agreed terms—tightening language on digital trade, agricultural imports and India’s \$500-billion import obligation.

The White House subsequently revised that document, dropping references to Indian imports of pulses,

softening language on digital trade commitments and replacing the definitive “will” with “intended” regarding the \$500-billion import target.

“The India-US joint statement on the framework for an interim agreement on reciprocal and mutually-beneficial trade was issued on February 7. The joint statement is the framework and remains the basis of our mutual understanding in the matter. Both sides will now work towards implementing this framework and finalising the interim agreement,” Jaiswal said.

Centre cuts toll rates on partially-open expressways

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi



PAY PER USE. Earlier, commuters were required to pay the higher expressway rate even when only certain sections were open

To ease traffic congestion, the Centre has amended toll rules to reduce user fees on national expressways that are not yet operational along their entire length.

Accordingly, the Ministry of Road Transport & Highways has amended the National Highways Fee (Determination of Rates and Collection) Rules, 2008.

The amended rules, National Highways Fee (Determination of Rates and Collection) (Amendment) Rules, 2026, will come into force on February 15, 2026.

Notably, the lower toll regime will remain in effect for one year from the date of implementation or until the expressway concerned becomes fully operational, whichever is earlier.

FEE UP 25%
Consequently, toll on partially-operational expressways will now be charged at rates applicable to national highway sections, instead of the earlier provision that allowed a 25 per cent higher fee for completed stretches of expressways.

Previously, commuters

were required to pay the higher expressway rate even when only certain sections were open, on the grounds that access-controlled corridors offer faster and more seamless travel.

The ministry said the revised provision is intended to promote the use of operational stretches of expressways, helping decongest parallel National Highways, speed up the movement of passengers and freight, and reduce pollution caused by traffic bottlenecks.

Petronet Q3 net up 5% on higher capacity use

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Petronet LNG on Thursday reported a 5 per cent rise in the December quarter net profit, as usage at its Kochi terminal rose to an all-time high.

Its net profit stood at ₹848 crore in the December quarter compared with ₹806 crore in the year-ago period, a company statement said.

The company, which operates two facilities at Dahej in Gujarat and Kochi in Kerala for import of natural gas in its liquid form (LNG), saw overall volume throughput rise 2 per cent. Capacity utilisation of the (17.5 million tonnes a year) Dahej terminal stood at 94 per cent in the current quarter (93 per cent).

“The robust financial performance of the current quarter was achieved due to efficiency in operations and higher capacity utilisation,” the company said.

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THE RAMARAJU SURGICAL COTTON MILLS LIMITED						
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CIN : L17111TN1939PLC002302						
Telephone No. 04563 - 235904						
E-mail : rscm@ramcotex.com Website : www.ramarajusurgical.com						
EXTRACT OF UNAUDITED CONSOLIDATED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED AND NINE MONTHS ENDED 31ST DECEMBER 2025						
Particulars	Quarter Ended			Nine Months Ended		Year Ended
	31-12-2025	30-09-2025	31-12-2024	31-12-2025	31-12-2024	
	Un-Audited	Un-Audited	Un-Audited	Un-Audited	Un-Audited	
1 Total income from operations	10,533.42	10,508.89	10,530.21	30,942.28	28,057.07	40,612.08
2 Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax, exceptional and extraordinary items	(2,228.06)	(1,471.78)	(2,121.63)	(5,292.88)	(4,817.80)	(6,042.16)
3 Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional Items) (Refer Note No.3)	(1,053.54)	364.60	(2,567.14)	(2,317.46)	(5,748.27)	(7,535.62)
4 Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional Items) (*)	5,952.22	1,709.70	3,429.65	8,475.30	2,188.83	1,704.52
5 Total Comprehensive Income / (Loss) for the period after tax (comprising Net Profit for the period after tax and Other Comprehensive Income after tax)	5,984.95	1,706.41	4,196.52	8,776.26	2,842.37	1,332.14
6 Equity Share Capital (Face value of ₹ 10/- each)	920.41	920.41	920.41	920.41	920.41	920.41
7 Reserves (excluding revaluation reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet of the previous year				3,39,249.25	2,32,949.74	2,30,519.10
8 Earning Per Share of ₹. 10/- each, (Not Annualised) (in ₹.)	64.68	18.58	37.26	92.08	23.56	18.52
9 Basic Diluted	64.68	18.58	37.26	92.08	23.56	18.52
(*) Includes Share of Net Profit of Associates, Net of Tax	6,744.90	1,623.20	5,350.72	10,404.76	6,689.61	7,582.23

NOTES:
1) The above is an extract of the detailed format of Financial Results filed with Stock Exchange under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligation and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Unaudited Quarter ended financial results are available on the Company's website at www.ramarajusurgical.com and on the website of the Stock Exchange where the shares of the company is listed at www.nse.co.in.
2) The above consolidated unaudited results for the quarter ended and nine month ended were reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors at their respective Meeting held on 12-02-2026. The Statutory Auditor have carried out Limited Review of the above results.
3) Key standalone financial information (Rs in Lakhs)

Particulars	Quarter Ended			Nine Months Ended		Year Ended
	31-12-2025	30-09-2025	31-12-2024	31-12-2025	31-12-2024	
	Un-Audited	Un-Audited	Un-Audited	Un-Audited	Un-Audited	
Total Income	9,202.21	10,404.42	11,915.16	28,417.69	29,214.96	40,686.31
Net Profit / (Loss) before exceptional items and tax	(1,550.72)	(845.64)	(1,481.78)	(3,649.39)	(3,485.48)	(4,432.07)
Net Profit / (Loss) before tax	(1,550.72)	(845.64)	(1,481.78)	(3,649.39)	(3,485.48)	(4,432.07)
Net Profit / (Loss) after Tax	(1,479.47)	(930.84)	(1,345.99)	(3,256.54)	(2,796.62)	608.10

4) The previous period figures have been re-grouped / re-stated wherever necessary to confirm to current year classification.

THE RAMARAJU SURGICAL COTTON MILLS LIMITED
N.R.K. RAMKUMAR RAJA
MANAGING DIRECTOR
(DIN : 01848373)

RAJAPALAYAM MILLS LIMITED						
Regd. Off: Rajapalayam Mills Premises, P.A.C. Ramasamy Raja Salai, Post Box No.1, Rajapalayam - 626 117, Tamil Nadu. CIN No.: L17111TN1936PLC002298 Telephone No. 04563-235666, Fax No. 04563-236520 E-Mail: rajacot@ramcotex.com, Website: www.rajapalayammills.co.in						
EXTRACT OF CONSOLIDATED UN-AUDITED STATEMENT OF PROFIT AND LOSS FOR THE QUARTER / NINE MONTHS ENDED 31 ST DECEMBER, 2025						
Sl. No.	Particulars	Quarter ended			Nine Months ended	
		31-12-2025	30-09-2025	31-12-2024	31-12-2025	31-12-2024
		(Un-Audited)	(Un-Audited)	(Un-Audited)	(Un-Audited)	(Un-Audited)
1	Total Income from operations	24,663.93	24,593.77	23,415.67	68,472.06	66,909.53
2	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (Before tax, exceptional items)	(1,197.88)	368.38	(2,562.18)	(2,346.27)	(7,409.81)
3	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional Items) (Refer Note No.3)	(1,053.54)	364.60	(2,567.14)	(2,317.46)	(5,748.27)
4	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional Items) (*)	5,952.22	1,709.70	3,429.65	8,475.30	2,188.83
5	Total Comprehensive Income / (Loss) for the period after tax (comprising Net Profit for the period after tax and Other Comprehensive Income after tax)	5,984.95	1,706.41	4,196.52	8,776.26	2,842.37
6	Equity Share Capital (Face value of ₹ 10/- each)	920.41	920.41	920.41	920.41	920.41
7	Reserves (excluding revaluation reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet of the previous year				3,39,249.25	2,32,949.74
8	Earning Per Share of ₹ 10/- each, (Not Annualised) (in ₹)	64.68	18.58	37.26	92.08	23.56
9	Basic Diluted	64.68	18.58	37.26	92.08	23.56
(*) Includes Share of Net Profit of Associates, Net of Tax		6,744.90	1,623.20	5,350.72	10,404.76	6,689.61

NOTES:
1) The above is an extract of the detailed format of quarter / nine months ended un-audited statement of profit and loss that has been filed with the Stock Exchange under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of quarter / nine months ended un-audited statement of profit and loss (Standalone and Consolidated) are available on the Company's website at www.rajapalayammills.co.in and on the website of the Bombay Stock Exchange www.bseindia.com.
2) The above un-audited financial results have been prepared in accordance with Indian Accounting Standards (Ind AS) prescribed under Section 133 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with relevant rules thereunder and in terms of regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosures Requirements) Regulations, 2015 (as amended). The said financial results were reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors at their Meeting held on 12-02-2026. The Statutory Auditors have carried out Limited Review of the above results and expressed an unmodified audit opinion.
3) Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax includes exceptional items, which represent the following items:

Particulars	Quarter ended			Nine Months ended		(₹ in Lakhs)
	31-12-2025	30-09-2025	31-12-2024	31-12-2025	31-12-2024	
	(Un-Audited)	(Un-Audited)	(Un-Audited)	(Un-Audited)	(Un-Audited)	
Profit on Sale of Investment in the Equity Shares	-	20.33	-	20.33	-	-
Profit / (Loss) on Sale of Property, Plant & Equipment	54.34	(24.12)	25.04	8.38	(0.29)	74.19
Total	54.34	(3.79)	25.04	28.71	(0.29)	74.19

4) Key standalone financial information:

Particulars	Quarter ended			Nine Months ended		(₹ in Lakhs)
	31-12-2025	30-09-2025	31-12-2024	31-12-2025	31-12-2024	
	(Un-Audited)	(Un-Audited)	(Un-Audited)	(Un-Audited)	(Un-Audited)	
Total Income	24,663.93	25,395.09	23,415.67	68,233.38	66,776.80	92,405.89
Net Profit / (Loss) before exceptional items and tax	(2,187.88)	1,529.71	(2,562.18)	(3,585.09)	(4,881.00)	(6,742.57)
Net Profit / (Loss) before tax	(1,053.54)	1,125.92	(2,567.14)	(3,556.34)	(4,881.25)	(6,688.38)
Net Profit / (Loss) after tax	(793.48)	847.82	(1,623.20)	(3,168.18)	(3,653.53)	(5,020.47)

5) The previous period figures have been re-grouped / re-stated wherever necessary.
6) The aforementioned Un-audited Financial Results are available on the Company's website at https://www.rajapalayammills.co.in/wp-content/uploads/2025/11/PY-2025-26-Q3.pdf and can also be accessed by scanning a Quick Response Code given below:
For RAJAPALAYAM MILLS LIMITED,
P.R. VENKATRAMA RAJA,
CHAIRMAN
(DIN: 00331408)

Muthoot Finance

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EXTRACT OF UNAUDITED STANDALONE & CONSOLIDATED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE NINE MONTHS ENDED **DECEMBER 31, 2025**

PARTICULARS	STANDALONE			CONSOLIDATED		
	9M FY 2026	9M FY 2025	% Increase	9M FY 2026	9M FY 2025	% Increase
Loan Asset (₹)	1,47,552	97,487	51%	1,64,720	1,11,308	48%
Total Revenue (₹)	19,444	12,267	59%	22,057	14,672	50%
Profit Before Tax (₹)	9,479	5,050	88%	9,721	5,334	82%
Profit After Tax (₹)	7,048	3,693	91%	7,209	3,908	84%
Net Worth (₹)	34,502	27,001	28%	35,624	27,962	27%
Earnings Per Share(₹10/- each)(Basic) (₹)	175.55	91.99	91%	180.36	96.03	88%
Book Value Per Share (%)	859.33	672.47	28%	887.21	696.34	27%

Note: The above is an extract of the detailed format of Unaudited Financial Results for nine months and is not a statutory advertisement required under SEBI guidelines. The detailed financials and investor presentation is available on the website of the Company at www.muthootfinance.com

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Creditable move

Linking deposit insurance premium to risk was overdue

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has flagged off a long-overdue banking reform by ushering in risk-based deposit insurance premiums, in place of a one-size-fits-all premium, from April 2026. Several expert panels, starting from the Narasimham Committee in 1998, have argued for the Deposit Insurance and Credit Guarantee Corporation (DICGC) to move from its flat premium to a risk-based regime to avoid moral hazard.



The idea met with pushback from co-operative banks on the ground that it would increase their premium burden. Others argued that risk-based premia would send disquieting signals to depositors on the soundness of banks. The RBI seems to have addressed both issues. Under the new system, instead of paying a flat premium at 0.12 per cent of assessable deposits, banks will pay differential premia based on their risk category, as assessed by DICGC. Banks will be segregated into two tiers. Under Tier 1 which will apply to scheduled commercial banks (SCBs), banks will be assigned risk ratings based on RBI's supervisory assessment, quantitative measures and the potential loss to DICGC from their failure. For Tier 2 banks (co-operative banks and regional rural banks), the risk rating will only use quantitative measures and potential loss to DICGC.

The RBI is perhaps constrained in exercising supervisory oversight on 1800-odd co-operative banks. For risk grading, a bank's capital adequacy, asset quality, liquidity, profitability ratios and RBI supervisory ratings for the last financial year will be used. However, reliance on back data may lead to late recognition of problems. Similarly, assessing a bank's governance based on its adherence to Board composition norms alone, seems inadequate. But since a more thorough assessment could lead to delays, the RBI has probably taken the middle path. Once banks are bucketed into risk categories, the riskiest ones will pay premium at the card rate (0.12 per cent of assessable deposits) and those rated less risky will pay 0.11 per cent, 0.10 per cent or 0.08 per cent, with discounts based on vintage. This system ensures that large SCBs earn significant savings on deposit insurance premia, while smaller/riskier banks do not face any immediate increases in premium outgo.

On disclosure, the RBI has mandated that banks stop disclosing the quantum of deposit insurance premia paid, with DICGC required to keep its risk ratings confidential. This may prevent systemic risks. But it is unfair to depositors as they cannot demand higher returns from riskier banks. However, the impact on DICGC's surpluses and balance sheet needs to be closely monitored. After the fivefold increase in deposit insurance in FY20, DICGC has seen its premium income rise at a much slower pace than insured deposits. It believes that its Deposit Insurance Fund at 2.3 per cent of insured deposits is in line with global norms. The fact remains that the DICGC has not burnt its fingers, as the RBI usually steps in with pre-emptive mergers/takeovers of banks in trouble.

POCKET

RAVIKANTH



BRAHMA CHELLANEY

For over two decades, the US has regarded India as a “natural partner” — a rising power whose geography, military capabilities, and democratic credentials made it indispensable to America's strategy in the Indo-Pacific. Five successive US administrations, Republican and Democratic alike, invested heavily in strengthening that partnership, treating India not just as a market, but as a long-term strategic bet. But the goodwill that the US built up with India over that period has been rapidly eroded since Donald Trump's return to the presidency last year. Trump's second presidency has brought repeated public insults and a bruising trade war, with the US using tariffs as tools of geopolitical coercion. The interim trade deal announced on February 2 may have halted the economic confrontation, but trust — the essential currency of any strategic partnership — is unlikely to be restored any time soon.

By reducing the effective US tariff burden on Indian goods from 50 per cent to 18 per cent, the newly announced deal will deliver short-term relief for India. But it comes with plenty of strings attached, including the requirement that India move towards near-zero tariffs on US industrial products and a wide range of agricultural goods. India's decision to open its sensitive agricultural sector — the country's largest employer — to a flood of imports from the US is already sparking a domestic backlash.

But that is not all. India has also agreed to purchase a whopping \$500 billion worth of American goods over the next five years, and to replace discounted Russian oil with US energy at market prices, which also implies additional transport costs. Meanwhile, the US offered no binding commitments to India.

This lopsided bargain looks nothing like a stable, reciprocal, rules-based trade partnership, and underscores how far US trade policy has drifted from World Trade Organization norms. It is probably best understood as a tactical de-escalation, not a strategic reconciliation.

The way the deal was announced reinforces this interpretation. Typically, bilateral agreements or joint statements are announced simultaneously in both capitals to signal equal partnership. The free-trade agreement India recently concluded with the European Union, which created a trade corridor



REUTERS

Trump trade truce won't restore bilateral ties

TRUST MATTERS. Strategic partnerships are sustained not by tariffs and threats, but by predictability, mutual respect, and restraint — qualities absent from Trump's presidency

encompassing roughly 25 per cent of global GDP and one-third of world trade, was touted by both sides as the “mother of all deals.”

A COMPLIANCE TEST

The US-India agreement, by contrast, was announced first by Trump, who portrayed it on his social-media platform as a favour to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, whose “request” for an agreement Trump had granted “out of friendship and respect.” Days later, the White House released a “joint statement” outlining the terms of the agreement at 5:00 a.m. Indian Standard Time.

The Trump administration then added injury to insult, announcing a presidential executive order authorising reimposition of punitive tariffs if the US deems India to have violated its commitment to halt all direct and indirect imports of Russian oil. By framing Indian energy imports as a US national-security issue, the administration has turned economic engagement into a compliance test. The message to India is unmistakable: autonomy will be tolerated only within US-approved limits.

India's leaders have framed the agreement as a win, noting that India now faces lower tariffs than China or

Vietnam. But this is a low bar for a relationship that successive US administrations described as “defining.” And they are probably well aware that Trump could still pull the rug out from under them. The arrangement's details have not yet been finalised, and Trump has a long history of changing his mind, scrapping deals, and layering on new demands.

Whatever happens next, India will not quickly forget Trump's past betrayals. Nor will it overlook his slights, such as branding India, whose GDP growth outpaces that of all other major economies, as a “dead economy” last July.

In a sense, Trump might have done India a favour. By exposing the raw transactionalism at the core of his foreign policy, he has left no doubt that, under his leadership, the US is not a reliable strategic partner. As a result,

By framing Indian energy imports as a US national-security issue, the administration has turned economic engagement into a compliance test

India's government is committed to diversifying the country's economic relationships away from the US, as underscored by its FTAs with the EU and the UK — an effort that will likely continue, regardless of the new trade agreement with the US.

Markets are similarly unlikely to put too much faith in the US. News of the trade deal did trigger a stock-market rally in India, but the gains are likely to be short-lived.

Strategic partnerships are sustained not by tariffs and threats, but by predictability, mutual respect, and restraint — qualities that have been conspicuously absent from Trump's presidency. The US should beware. Whatever short-term concessions Trump secures through bullying and coercion will be dwarfed by the long-term costs of destabilising a partnership that, as previous administrations recognised, is vital to American interests in the Indo-Pacific and beyond.

The writer is Professor Emeritus of Strategic Studies at the New Delhi-based Center for Policy Research, Fellow at the Robert Bosch Academy in Berlin and the author of ‘Water, Peace, and War: Confronting the Global Water Crisis’ (Rowman & Littlefield, 2013). Copyright: Project Syndicate, 2026. www.project-syndicate.org

Story of a correction in EU textiles trade policy

EU repealed anti-dumping duty on certain polyester yarn exports, after being convinced by firm-level evidence

Chocko Valliappa

The renewed enthusiasm around the EU-India trade deal, particularly the reduction of tariffs on Indian textiles, is understandable. For an industry that employs millions and sits at the intersection of manufacturing, exports, and livelihoods, improved market access to Europe is not a small achievement.

But trade outcomes rarely emerge in isolation. They are shaped by history, precedent, and moments when evidence quietly reshapes policy. One such moment from the early 1990s offers a useful lens through which to view today's optimism.

A recent observation by Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal highlights a persistent paradox. Bangladesh, a country geographically smaller than Odisha, exports \$45-47 billion worth of textiles and apparel annually. India, despite scale, integrated value chains, and long industrial experience, exports \$36-40 billion. The gap is not a reflection of capability; it is largely a consequence of differential market access and regulatory treatment over time.

In earlier decades, India benefited from its classification as a developing country under the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (GATT). Through the Generalised System of Preferences (GSP), Indian textile exports enjoyed tariff concessions in the European market. Those preferences mattered,



EARNED OVER TIME. Confidence in trade frameworks PERIASAMY M

particularly when capital, technology, and logistics were still evolving.

The late 1980s marked a shift. The European Union initiated anti-dumping investigations into polyester and cotton yarn imports from India, relying on data drawn from an earlier economic context. Several audits followed across Indian mills. One episode at Sri Meenakshi Mills — founded by my great-grandfather and no longer part of the family — became emblematic of the risks of opacity. EU auditors were repeatedly denied access to data, including, on one occasion, the explanation that there was “a snake in the room.”

The outcome was inevitable. The EU imposed anti-dumping duties of 7.8 per cent on certain polyester cotton yarn exports from India.

What followed, however, is less remembered. India, through the Synthetic and Rayon Textiles Export

Promotion Council (SRTEPC), formally contested the findings and requested an exporter review. The EU agreed and selected five Indian companies as representative samples for detailed investigation. Sri Valliappa Textiles, run by my father C Valliappa, was one of them.

For the companies involved, this was more than a routine audit. It was a rigorous test of whether Indian cost competitiveness would be judged on evidence or assumptions.

EXACTING REVIEW PROCESS

The review process was exacting. Normal values, export prices, currency movements, internal efficiencies, and cost structures were all scrutinised. Every number had to reconcile. Every explanation had to stand up to forensic examination.

When the audit team arrived, the tone was unmistakable. Twelve EU auditors conducted an intense two-day interrogation. One point of contention became symbolic: packing costs.

Sri Valliappa Textiles' packing cost was ₹3.30 per kilogram, compared with an industry norm of about ₹4.50/kg. The auditors initially insisted on applying the industry average. The counter-argument was straightforward: we manufactured our own paper cones, giving us structurally lower costs. Why should inefficiency elsewhere be imputed to us?

The discussion grew tense. At one point, the auditors discontinued the

audit. The response was firm but factual: an audit must examine reality, not hypothetical benchmarks. After a pause, they returned, verified the data in detail, and accepted the costing.

The conclusion of the EU review was decisive. Dumping margins for Indian producers were found to be below the EU's *de minimis* threshold. There was no material evidence of dumping. The anti-dumping duty on Indian polyester yarns was repealed, a decision formalised in EU regulation in 1994.

That ruling did more than remove a tariff. It quietly reaffirmed a principle that remains relevant today: trade remedies lose legitimacy when they outlive the facts on which they were built.

As the EU-India trade deal gathers momentum, this episode serves as a reminder that confidence in trade frameworks is earned over time. Today's optimism rests not only on negotiated text, but on a longer arc in which data, transparency, and persistence have occasionally prevailed over presumption.

Sometimes, the most consequential shifts in trade relations do not come from announcements or summits, but from moments when evidence forces policy to recalibrate. That is worth remembering as India's textile story with Europe enters a more hopeful chapter.

The writer is Founder and MD, Vee Technologies and Vice Chairman, The Sona Group

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Women farmers' woes

This refers to ‘Uplifting women farmers’ (February 12). While it is necessary to extend land-owning rights to women farmers, there is a larger group of women cultivators/workers who work on others' farms for a living. What compels attention is the poor quality of life — their day starts much earlier in the morning to prepare food for the family (if available), work in farms and return home to serve the family till late night. An estimated 52-75 per cent of Indian women engaged in agriculture are illiterate. There is

wage disparity between male and female. Many women participate in agricultural work as unpaid subsistence labour. The silver lining is that the new Indian Labour Codes aim to empower landless women labourers through guaranteed minimum wages, equal pay and enhanced social security.

YG Chouksey

Pune

Ensuring durable liquidity

Appropos, ‘CRR can be used to provide liquidity’ (February 12). India's monetary challenge today is

not a lack of instruments but the discipline in their use. With growth uneven and inflation sticky, the RBI must resist pseudo easing via surplus liquidity. Daily tools — repo, VRR, and SDF — must anchor short-term rates firmly, within the bandwidth. Durable liquidity is better attained through forex swaps and maturity-tuning and open market operations. Outright bond purchases may open up a runaway narrative of fiscal overreach. In the context of these uncertain times, CRR tends to remain a rough tool, to be kept for an excess credit regime.

The RBI needs to steer deftly in separating rate signalling, yield-curve management, and managing the forex rate without affecting the G-sec market. The crux lies in aiming at precision over discretion.

R Narayanan

Navi Mumbai

Banking ethics

This refers to ‘Ethics in banking should not be treated as a soft theme: RBI Deputy Governor’ (February 12). The Deputy Governor, in his speech, has highlighted transparency in

communication and the need to move beyond mere box-ticking compliance. While transparency is essential, ethical standards must also extend to marketing practices. Loan customers are often strongly persuaded to purchase life or medical insurance policies. Though such products may have merit, the choice should remain entirely voluntary and free from any pressure. Ethics should similarly guide the handling of customer grievances.

R Mohan

Kumbakonam, TN

Give tourism a boost

It has the potential to drive growth, jobs

Rahul Pandit

Elephants are not raised on peanuts. India must create 10 million jobs annually to employ its youth and preserve social harmony. With 48 million employed and every rupee invested generating 3.5 times more jobs than the economy's average, tourism offers a transformational jobs engine for a nation hungry for growth. Yet, with a mere 0.05 per cent of the Union Budget allocated to tourism, India underserves a golden opportunity.

Tourism contributes 6.7 per cent to India's GDP. It is 15 per cent for the UAE, and 20 per cent for Thailand. Were India to raise tourism's contribution to 15 per cent by 2035, the sector could employ 100 million people and add an incremental \$1 trillion to GDP — roughly the output of a mid-size G20 economy.

THE PARADOX

India, with 44 UNESCO World Heritage Sites — and blessed with mountains, temples, palaces, and beaches — should be a tourism superpower. Instead, it is held back by policy drift, patchy execution, and a neglect of the basics. Capacity is central to the problem. The estimated daily lodging demand is five million beds, yet India has barely 190,000 branded hotel rooms. Vietnam has more than 200,000; the UAE, 220,000; Thailand, 900,000; Japan, two million; and China, seven million. India's weakness is most visible in international tourism. In 2024, it welcomed 10 million foreign visitors, while 30 million Indians travelled abroad, producing a net forex outflow. Peer comparisons are sobering. Vietnam attracted 18 million visitors, the UAE 19 million, and Thailand 36 million.

Three reforms would unlock much of this potential. First, move tourism to the Concurrent List to end the Centre-State coordination quagmire. Second, rapidly scale supply. Third, fix the last-mile experience.

India should aim to add one million branded hotel rooms by 2035. Fragmented incentives can be knitted into a national framework. Ten-year CGST reimbursements, modelled on the Northeast UNNATI scheme, will spur investment in Jammu and Kashmir, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh and Bihar. Existing State incentives — Maharashtra and Assam's 15-year SGST refunds and Odisha's 30 per cent capital subsidy — could be standardised.



LEVERAGE. India has the potential to be a tourism power

Simultaneously, homestays should be scaled to 500,000 rooms through online Aadhaar-based registration and digitally self-certified tiered quality standards. Modest grants ₹1 lakh/₹2 lakh per rural/urban room, tied to basic hygiene and safety norms, and paired with partnerships with branded operators, could formalise supply without stifling local enterprise.

Financing need not be a constraint. A \$10 billion India Tourism Fund, structured as a sovereign-private InvIT, could anchor the expansion. Select assets of ITDC and State tourism corporations could seed the fund.

Tourism succeeds or fails on last-mile quality: clean toilets, sufficient parking, safe streets for women, and efficient queues. India underperforms on all four. A nationwide “Mission Cleanest Cities” could grade districts on civility, safety, and cleanliness, with a slice of GST transfers linked to measurable outcomes.

Decommissioned agniveers could be deployed as tourist police. Pilgrimage queues should be digitised, as at Mumbai's Siddhivinayak temple. Functional infrastructure — electric shuttles, shaded walkways, and multilingual signage — should be the norm, not an exception.

Skills, too, must catch up. Vocational training should be rapidly scaled through hotel-school hybrids and stackable online certification overseen by the National Institute of Hospitality.

The Union Budget last year promised infrastructure status for tourism, the upgrading of 50 destinations, and the ‘Heal in India’ initiative. None has yet been meaningfully implemented. What is needed is sustained attention from the top. A Prime Minister-chaired Standing Committee on Tourism could cut through inter-ministerial silos and enforce delivery.

The writer is Member-CII National Council on Tourism, Member-UP CM's Economic Advisory Group



R SUNDARAM

Walk into any affluent home today, and you'll likely find children as young as four or five swiping through tablets, playing educational apps on smartphones, or watching videos on laptops. Now step into a government primary school in Tamil Nadu. The contrast is stark. Most children here have never touched a computer before entering the classroom, let alone owned one.

This digital divide is real and troubling. Recognising this gap, philanthropists and corporate donors have stepped in with a well-intentioned solution: donate used laptops to non-profit organisations, which then hire computer teachers — many of them graduates with degrees in Computer Applications — and place them in government schools. It's a practical response to a pressing problem, especially since the government finds it nearly impossible to hire these teachers directly. Years of capitulating to teachers' union demands have created a situation where regular government teachers enjoy such high salaries and benefits that appointing new staff for specialised subjects has become financially unviable.

But here's the uncomfortable question we need to ask: in our rush to bridge the digital divide, are we inadvertently widening a more fundamental gap?

Government schools have been criticised for decades for one persistent failing: they promote rote learning instead of developing analytical skills and critical thinking in students. It's a valid criticism that deserves serious attention. Yet the current push toward digital literacy does nothing to address this core problem. In fact, it may even reinforce it.

Consider what actually happens in a typical digital literacy class. Children learn to open files, save documents, perform basic operations in spreadsheets, and format text in word processors. These are useful skills, certainly, but let's be honest about what they are: a series of mechanical steps to achieve predetermined outcomes. Click here, type there, save like this. There's no questioning involved, no problem-solving required, no analytical thinking at play. It's rote learning dressed up in modern clothes.

And here's the twist that makes this even more problematic: these very skills that we're so eager to teach are rapidly becoming obsolete. With AI tools like Claude and ChatGPT now capable of handling complex document formatting, data analysis, and digital tasks instantly, how relevant will these step-by-step procedures be in five or ten years?

None of this means that computer skills are unimportant or that children



SUDHAKARA JAIN

Digital divide not the real problem in schools

BACK TO BASICS. More than digital literacy, what govt school children need is good teaching and robust pedagogy

shouldn't learn them. Technology is undeniably part of their future. But we're approaching this backwards, putting the cart firmly before the horse.

What government school children urgently need is something far more fundamental: a strong foundation in core subjects taught through robust pedagogy. Real mathematics that develops problem-solving abilities, not just memorisation of formulas. Science that encourages observation, experimentation, and questioning, not just reproduction of textbook answers. Languages that build genuine communication skills and comprehension. Social studies that help children understand their society and their place in it.

These subjects, when taught well, naturally cultivate the analytical thinking and questioning mindset that we claim to value. A child who learns to work through a challenging math

problem, who designs and conducts a simple science experiment, who analyses why historical events unfolded as they did — that child is learning to think. And a child who knows how to think will pick up digital skills quickly and, more importantly, use them effectively.

This brings us to a proposal for those who genuinely want to improve education in government schools. If philanthropists and companies serious about their Corporate Social Responsibility programmes truly want to make a difference, they should incorporate in their schemes of assistance quality teaching of core subjects.

In addition to funding computer labs and digital literacy programmes, imagine if they partnered with NGOs that excel at identifying outstanding teachers in mathematics, science, languages, and social studies. Imagine if they seconded these excellent teachers to government primary schools where quality instruction is desperately needed. Imagine if they invested in improving how core subjects are taught rather than adding more peripheral programmes.

This approach would address the real crisis in government school education: not the lack of computers, but the quality of teaching and learning in

fundamental subjects. Once children have learned to think critically, to question, to analyse — once they've developed strong foundations in core subjects — the digital skills will follow naturally. They'll not only learn them faster but use them more intelligently.

The digital divide is real, but we may be measuring the wrong gap. Government school children don't need to master Word formatting or Excel formulas as much as they need teachers who can transform rote learning into genuine understanding. They need classrooms where questions are encouraged, where thinking is valued over memorisation, where core subjects are taught with depth and engagement.

That's the divide that truly matters. That's the gap we should be racing to bridge.

None of this means that computer skills are unimportant or that children shouldn't learn them. Technology is undeniably part of their future. But we're approaching this backwards, putting the cart firmly before the horse.

INTEGRATE LIFE SKILLS

Here is another thought on education. While digital literacy empowers students with technical capabilities it is equally crucial to learn to navigate life's unpredictable nature. Unlike computers that produce consistent programmable outputs, human existence is marked by the vicissitudes of fortune — unexpected health crisis, shifting family dynamics and relationships that defy algorithmic logic. There is a risk that excessive exposure to technology's deterministic world may foster an illusion among children that life itself follows predictable patterns with controllable outcomes.

To counter this, education must consciously integrate life skills that prepares students for ambiguity, loss and change. Teaching emotional intelligence conflict resolution financial literacy during hardship coping mechanism for grief and disappointment becomes as essential as coding or digital communication. Students need spaces to understand that failure is not a bug to be fixed but often a natural part of growth, that human relationships require patience and forgiveness rather than inputs and outputs and that uncertainty, while uncomfortable, can be a catalyst for creativity and personnel development.

Is it possible to deliver such a composite education which combines foundational learning in language, maths, science and social studies with alongside digital and computational skills and the skills needed to cope with the “mess called life”

By balancing technical education with humanistic wisdom we ensure that bridging the digital divide does not inadvertently widen an emotional psychological gap leaving young people competent in technology yet unprepared for the messy complexity of life itself.

The writer retired as Member, Ordnance Factories, Ministry of Defence

thehindubusinessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO **TODAY.**

February 13, 2006

PSBs cagey on getting more freedom to appoint auditors

Amidst the clamour for freedom to manage their own affairs, banks feel that the Government's decision to grant autonomy to public sector banks to appoint statutory central auditors and branch auditors is something they could have done without.

Air Sahara cancels 30 flights after pilots' mass sick leave

The operations of Air Sahara were affected on Sunday after 30 of the airline pilots went on mass sick leave, forcing the airline to cancel 30 flights. “The important thing is that none of our passengers are stranded at any airport. We have put them on Jet Airways, Indian Airlines, and wherever we could find seats,” a top official of the airline said.

IT sector may need \$2.6 b to train 1 m professionals in 3 yrs

Even as the education system churns out three million graduates and 4 lakh engineers every year, the IT industry may have to spend up to \$2.6 billion in training an additional one million professionals over the next three years to make them employable in IT services and BPO sectors, Mr Mohandas Pai, Chief Financial Officer of Infosys Technologies, said.

Uncertainty over North American trade pact intensifies

Catherine Lucey

White House trade adviser Peter Navarro said the North American trade pact has “significant flaws” ahead of negotiations over the deal, expressing worries about China shipping goods through Mexico and Canada. Uncertainty over the future of the deal, which was negotiated by Donald Trump in his first term, has intensified, with the president asking aides why he should not withdraw from the agreement entirely, according to people familiar with those discussions.

“I can tell you this that USMCA has some significant flaws in it, and it's going to be reevaluated in July. The

great Jamieson Greer, our US trade representative, will be taking the lead on that,” Navarro said.

“But nothing ever happens in the White House without the commander-in-chief, particularly on trade, so as the boss says, let's see what happens.”

While Trump has been privately musing over exiting the pact, he has stopped short of flatly signalling that he will do so, according to the people familiar.

The US-Mexico-Canada Agreement is set for a mandatory review before a possible extension on July 1. That process was expected to be routine but Trump is demanding additional trade concessions from the two major



PETER NAVARRO. White House trade advisor REUTERS

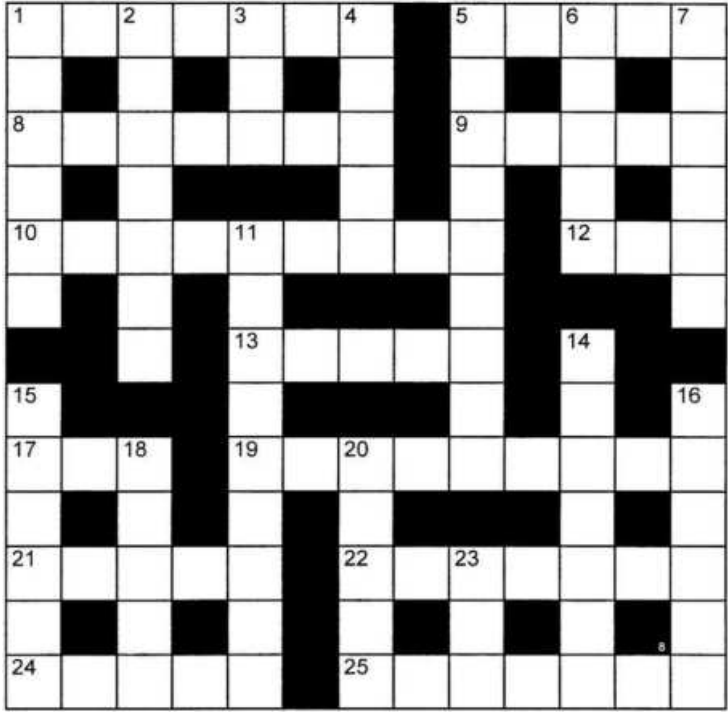
trading partners and has sought to pressure them over other issues such as migration, drug trafficking and

defence, further straining ties.

Navarro on Thursday cited concerns about the transshipment of Chinese goods, when products from the country enter Canada and Mexico before being ultimately shipped to the US.

“One of the things that's really troubling right now, and should be troubling to the American people, is that Mexico, and to an extent, Canada, are basically being used by — staging areas for countries like China, some of the European countries, many Asian countries, Japan, Korea,” Navarro added. “They leveraged NAFTA and now USMCA to get into our markets in a way which essentially is tariff avoidance at best and tariff evasion at worst.” BLOOMBERG

● BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2616



EASY

ACROSS

- To soothe, cheer (7)
- Apply piece to mend (5)
- Placed in a row (5,2)
- Have actual being (5)
- Italian hors d'oeuvre (9)
- Change colour (3)
- Rub out (5)
- Human seat (3)
- One frequently associating with another (9)
- Meat dressing (5)
- Recount, relate events (7)
- Deal with, give therapy (5)
- Had pleasure in (7)

DOWN

- Underground storage (6)
- Watch, check, supervise (7)
- Aged (3)
- Makes a recording of (5)
- Outstanding people, events (9)
- In position 'c' (5)
- Great dislike (6)
- Having foreknowledge (9)
- Avoidance of noise or display (7)
- Small private room (6)
- Certainly, in truth (6)
- Temporary stop (5)
- Ecclesiastical residence (5)
- British government of India (3)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

- It is quiet enjoyment for MC to be so disposed (7)
- Put a piece on for an old fool (5)
- Formed a queue in duple formation (5,2)
- Be discriminating against women, say, and lose head (5)
- Hors d'oeuvre turns into tapas in Italy (9)
- Dull yellow enamel starts to stain (3)
- Camera seldom shows how to efface it (5)
- Have a drink once round the track (3)
- A close associate sheds light on the lower deck (9)
- It sounds like the origin of ketchup (5)
- To give running commentary might earn tar some change (7)
- Buy the drinks for a special occasion (5)
- Eye on DJ one used with satisfaction (7)

DOWN

- Stock of wine one might recall having (6)
- A lizard given some responsibility in class (7)
- Of long standing or long duration initially (3)
- Records how one will try to provide arras (5)
- Remarkable things make me hope Ann can be converted (9)
- Two diatonic degrees with two ahead? (5)
- Dislike of unravelling thread (6)
- Having foresight, will have price sent out (9)
- Seclusion vicar could have had in extremes of poverty (7)
- A privy near the top of the tower (6)
- In truth I'd need of getting sorted out (6)
- Wait momentarily for the sea to get up like this (5)
- It means to change the parish minister's residence (5)
- Under British rule India gave up alcoholic beverage (3)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2615

ACROSS 1. Right 4. Dropped 8. Clown 9. Lateran 10. Irk 11. Elaborate 12. Item 13. Blue 18. Artichoke 20. Tag 21. Instant 22. Churn 23. Needed 24. Dress

DOWN 1. Recrimination 2. Grockle 3. Tender 4. Dollar 5. Option 6. Parka 7. Donkey-engines 14. Lettuce 15. Scrawl 16. Potted 17. Fenced 19. Taste

QUICKLY.

Govt's 5% BHEL stake sale subscribed 1.34 times



New Delhi: The government's 5 per cent stake sale in Bharat Heavy Electricals Ltd (BHEL) closed with 1.34 times subscription after receiving enthusiastic response from retail and institutional investors. "The second day of Bharat Heavy Electricals Ltd OFS closed with enthusiastic response from retail investors. The issue was subscribed 1.34 times," Department of Investment and Public Asset Management Secretary Arunish Chawla said on X. Shares of BHEL closed at ₹260.40, down 0.10 per cent over the previous close. **m**

Franklin Templeton plans to reach out to women

New Delhi: In a bid to deepen financial inclusion and expand women's participation in capital markets, Franklin Templeton India on Thursday said it has launched a nationwide investor education campaign for creating awareness about MFs among women. The initiative highlights the growing recognition that financial literacy, particularly among women, is key to the country's long-term socio-economic progress. "Financial literacy among women is fundamental to India's long-term socio-economic progress. While urban centres have made meaningful advances, lakhs of women across Bharat, especially in tier-2 and tier-3 regions, remain underserved in terms of access to financial knowledge and tools," Avinash Satwalekar, President, Franklin Templeton India, said. **m**

Bulk, block deals dip 11% on weak market sentiments

Suresh P Iyengar

Bulk and block deals in January have fallen 11 per cent to ₹23,148 crore against ₹26,008 crore logged in the same period last year, on the back of a pull-back in market valuations and growing economic uncertainty. However, bulk and blocks in this fiscal (up to January), at ₹5.32 lakh crore have already exceeded the ₹5.23 lakh crore recorded in the entire FY25, according to data sourced from primebdtatabase.com. The large bulk deals involved that of Hindustan Copper (₹1,600 crore), Vodafone Idea (₹706 crore), ZF Commercial Vehicle Control Systems India (₹633 crore), Brainbees Solutions (₹567 crore), Polycabs India (₹559 crore), Aavas Financiers (₹283 crore), Aditya Birla Lifestyle Brands (₹261 crore), Bharat Coking Coal (₹216 crore), Kalyan Jewellers (₹213 crore). Similarly, the big deals in block segment includes Axis

Lenskart jumps 10% after blockbuster Q3

Madhu Balaji

Shares of Lenskart Solutions soared 14 per cent in early trade to ₹532.40 on Thursday, a fresh 52-week high, following a sharp jump in December quarter earnings, driven by revenue growth and margin expansion. The stock closed 10 per cent higher at ₹513 against the previous close of ₹467.60. The eyewear retailer posted a multifold rise in consolidated profit after tax to ₹132.7 crore in the December quarter, up from ₹1.8 crore in the same period a year ago. Revenue from operations rose 38 per cent year on year to ₹2,308 crore (₹1,669 crore).

BROKERAGE OPTIMISM Brokerages described the quarterly performance as a

IT stocks continue to bleed on AI fear

NOSEDIVE. Nifty IT index crashes 5.5%; biggies such as TCS, Infosys, Wipro plunge 15-18 per cent YTD

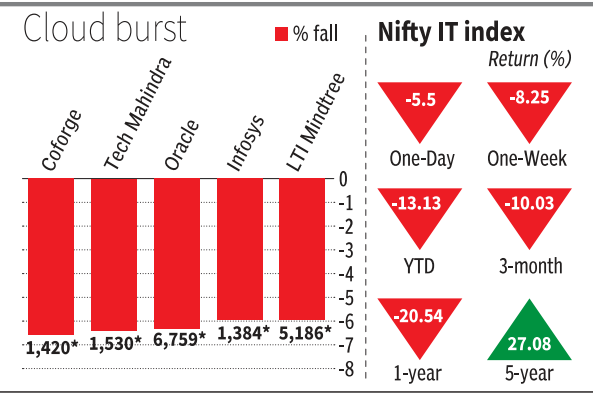
Madhu Balaji

IT stocks came under heavy selling pressure on Thursday in line with Wall Street peers. The Nifty IT index declined sharply by 5.5 per cent, as investor concerns mounted over the potential impact of artificial intelligence-led disruption on software services earnings, as the new advanced AI models could automate several traditional IT services, potentially impacting future growth. However, BSE Sensex and NSE Nifty were relatively stable, as they dropped 0.66 per cent and 0.57 per cent respectively.

AT YEAR LOWS Major IT names such as Infosys, Wipro, TCS, Coforge and HCL Tech were among the top losers on the index. Heavyweight Infosys ended 6 per cent lower at ₹1,386. TCS

settled 5.49 per cent lower at ₹2,750.10 after hitting a 52-week low of ₹2,740. Wipro also hit a 52-week low of ₹218.50 before closing 4.67 per cent lower at ₹219.08. Amidst AI threat, Nifty IT index crashed over 13 per cent YTD. IT majors such as TCS, Infosys lost over 15 per cent YTD, while Wipro fared poor by falling over 18 per cent. Tech Mahindra was better with 5 per cent drop. Market participants said the drop was driven by intensifying fears that AI-driven automation could pressure billing rates and reduce demand for certain service lines, potentially weighing on medium-term revenue visibility.

NEW VISA RULE THREAT Reports that the Trump administration is expanding in an effort to revoke the US citizenship for foreign-born Americans as it works to curb



immigration, also spooked the sentiment, as Indian IT majors employ them as well, said analysts. The sell-off comes amid broader global debates over the pace at which generative AI and automation tools are being adopted by enterprises, prompting investors to reassess growth assumptions for IT companies. Globally, AI is reshaping

markets by compressing margins in service-intensive sectors and increasing concentration-led volatility. In India, this technology shift is likely to structurally transform IT services by accelerating delivery timelines and automating volume-driven tasks, thereby challenging the traditional headcount-based outsourcing model, Vinod Nair, Head of

SEBI eyes lower cost of capital to boost competitiveness

Akshata Gorde

SEBI is working on lowering the cost of capital and rationalising regulatory compliance requirements to strengthen India's competitiveness. Speaking at the sixth Annual International Research Conference hosted by the National Institute of Securities Markets (NISM) on Thursday, SEBI Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey said, "Cost efficiency of all our measures is important. If you have to build competitiveness, then there is a compliance burden on regulation. It is too high in terms of cost and time. To that extent, the competitiveness also goes down."

As part of this effort, SEBI is working on a regulatory impact assessment framework, an initiative announced earlier by the Finance Minister in the Budget. A committee led by the

Chief Economic Advisor will guide this exercise. burdens. To support evidence-based policymaking, the regulator is also setting up a Centre for Regulatory Studies. "It will be a high-level, permanent centre that will support ongoing research," Pandey said, adding that it would collaborate with academic and policy institutions to examine the impact of regulations on market development, access to finance and overall efficiency.

NSDL ISSUE On the recent technical disruption at National Securities Depository Ltd, Pandey said systems are now functioning normally. SEBI is awaiting a detailed root-cause analysis, which will be placed before its Technical Advisory Committee. Based on the findings, the regulator will consider short-, medium- and long-term corrective measures.

Petition against WeWork IPO withdrawn

Our Bureau

Rishab Agarwal, the petitioner who moved the Bombay High Court against WeWork India's initial public offering, has withdrawn his petition unconditionally before the Bombay High Court on Wednesday. Agarwal challenged aspects of disclosures in the WeWork prospectus, asserting that certain regulatory complaints were not fully reflected in the documents. The court disposed of the writ petition as withdrawn. The matter was listed before a Division Bench of Justice RI Chagla and Justice Advait Sethna.

"Unlike the earlier petitions filed by Vinay Bansal and Hemant Kulshrestha, Agarwal's challenge was premised entirely on allegations sourced from complaints filed by Sterling and Wilson Renewable Energy, an entity separately engaged in protracted litigation against another Embassy Group company," said a WeWork India spokesperson. "The resolution of all three petitions reaffirms the integrity of India's securities regulatory framework and sends a clear message that judicial processes cannot be misused for extraneous commercial purposes," the spokesperson said.

Bansal and Hemant Kulshrestha were dismissed by the Bombay High Court on December 1, declining to interfere with SEBI's approval of the IPO. The WeWork India spokesperson added that the sequential timing and coordinated nature of the three petitions reveal a pattern of orchestrated legal harassment, designed to manufacture uncertainty around the company's business. "The resolution of all three petitions reaffirms the integrity of India's securities regulatory framework and sends a clear message that judicial processes cannot be misused for extraneous commercial purposes," the spokesperson said.

NSE appoints Rothschild as advisor for IPO

Our Bureau

The National Stock Exchange (NSE) has appointed Rothschild & Co as an independent advisor for its initial public offering (IPO), after the market regulator's long-pending clearance last month and the board's subsequent approval of the listing plan. "IPO Committee has selected Rothschild as an Independent advisor to oversee the IPO process, after meeting various agencies based on technical and commercial proposals," NSE said in a statement.

EVALUATION PROCESS The advisor will spearhead a

transparent and governance-led process of appointing key intermediaries for the issue, including book-running lead managers (BRLMs) and legal counsels. The role will also ensure "information parity, consistent stakeholder communication and comprehensive documentation of decisions," the exchange said. Rothschild's mandate includes "developing an objective evaluation framework, defining clear selection criteria and managing all stages of the selection process — from documentation and clarifications to back-off coordination and consolidation of evaluation feedback of internal stakeholders." NSE had first filed draft red herring prospectus pa-



GOING PUBLIC. The independent advisor will oversee the selection of BRLMs

pers with SEBI in 2016. However, the IPO was stalled following regulatory scrutiny related to the co-location and dark fibre matter and subsequent governance and compliance concerns. Over the past few years, the exchange has taken steps

to address regulatory observations, settle legacy issues and strengthen governance processes. The NOC received from SEBI on January 30 paved the way for reviving the IPO process, subject to compliance with applicable norms. A week ago, the NSE board approved the IPO via an offer for sale by existing shareholders. LIC, State Bank of India, Canada Pension Plan Investment Board and Singapore's Temasek are some of its major shareholders. It further re-constituted an IPO committee, led by Tablesh Pandey, including public interest directors such as Srinivas Injeti and the exchange's MD and CEO Ashishkumar Chauhan.

BROKER'S CALL.

Systematix Institutional Equities

HINDUSTAN FOODS (BUY)
Target: ₹665
CMP: ₹525.05
Hindustan Foods' management maintained its upbeat medium-term outlook on the Q3FY26 earnings call. Reiterating its aspiration of topline growth at over 20 per cent, it also guided for FY26E/27E profits at ₹140-145 crore/ ₹200-220 crore respectively — indicating earnings' growth of nearly 2x over FY25-27 — driven by a combination of legacy and new business segments. Hindustan Foods remains bullish on domestic demand pick-up in ice creams, packaged water/beverages and foods (aided by GST cuts), and exports in footwear and OTC pharma on US tariff relaxations and US/UK trade deals. Revenue grew 14 per cent to ₹1,000 crore. With new business segments getting over 70 per cent share of fresh capex planned in FY26, the transformation at Hindustan Foods — adding new marquee and mid-sized clients; high-growth segments of footwear, ice cream and healthcare (collectively c.33 per cent of FY26E sales); and the shared-manufacturing model — is gaining momentum. We expect the combined diversification of clients, segments and operating model to deliver potentially richer return ratios, going forward. We adjust our FY26E/FY27E EPS estimates by -2 per cent +/3 per cent respectively, and maintain our BUY rating with TP of ₹665, valuing the stock at P/E of 40x on FY27E EPS (unchanged). We expect Hindustan Foods' current one-year forward P/E (33x) to re-rate based on robust project pipeline, improving RoE and healthy earnings' growth trajectory.

Choice International

ASHOK LEYLAND (ADD)
Target: ₹225
CMP: ₹210.85
In Q3FY26, Ashok Leyland (AL) delivered its highest-ever volumes and revenue. Revenue rose 21.7 per cent year on year, supported by GST-led price rationalisation and a revival in freight demand. EBITDA grew 26.7 per cent and margin improved to 13.3 per cent, reflecting operating leverage and disciplined cost control. Volume momentum was broad-based, with domestic M&HCV and LCV industries growing 24 per cent and 23 per cent, respectively, while AL continued to outperform in LCVs with 30 per cent growth. AL continued to gain market share across key segments, with domestic M&HCV share at 30.9 per cent YTD-FY26 and LCV share at 12.7 per cent, supported by strong execution and an expanding network. Recent launches align well with customer preference for higher productivity and lower total cost of ownership, while new LCV offering enhances competitiveness in last-mile logistics. We value AL's core business at 22x on FY28E EPS, arriving at a value of ₹200. We assign a value of ₹18 to Hinduja Leyland Finance and ₹7 to Switch Mobility, resulting in a target price of ₹225. We downgrade the rating to 'Add' from 'Buy' due to recent stock price appreciation and near-term margin pressure from commodity headwinds, while remaining positive on long-term fundamentals and growth prospects.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: **blmarketwatch@gmail.com**

TODAY'S PICK.

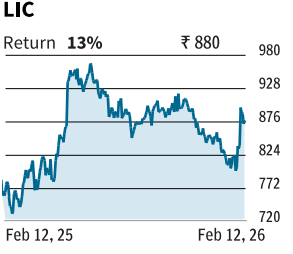
LIC (₹880.75): BUY

Akhil Nallamuthu

bl_research_bureau

The stock of Life Insurance Corporation of India garnered nearly 13 per cent gain last week, covering up losses it experienced in the preceding nine weeks.

So far this week, it is down 2.3 per cent. This correction is likely to be temporary as the price action indicates a strong shift in momentum in favour of the bulls. So, the ongoing blip is likely to be arrested by the support at ₹870, a support where both 21- and 50-day moving averages coincide. We expect the stock to



resume the rally and appreciate to ₹950 in the near term. So, buy at ₹880 and ₹860. Stop-loss can be ₹840. On a rally to ₹915 and ₹930, revise the stop-loss to ₹890 and ₹910 respectively. Exit at ₹950.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

25849 » Nifty 50 Futures

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
25750	25580	25960	26100	Support ahead; consider fresh shorts only below 25800.

₹920 » HDFC Bank

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
915	905	925	935	Go short on a rise to 925; stop-loss can be placed at 935.

₹1387 » Infosys

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1350	1300	1400	1420	Go short on a rise to 1400; stop-loss can be at 1420.

₹317 » ITC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
316	310	320	330	Buy the stock if it surpasses 320; stop-loss can be 315.

₹276 » ONGC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
272	270	278	282	Go long if the price dips to 272; place a stop-loss at 265.

₹1449 » Reliance Ind.

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1435	1410	1475	1500	Go long if the stock drops to 1435; stop-loss can be 1410.

₹1192 » SBI

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1175	1150	1200	1225	Buy the stock if it drops to 1175; place a stop-loss at 1150.

₹2751 » TCS

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2700	2650	2800	2875	The stock witnessing high volatility; avoid fresh positions.

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers					▼ 146.65 pts.
	Close(%)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
ICICI Bank	1430.00	37.43	18.06	8.68	
Bajaj Finance	999.10	17.55	33.93	2.25	
State Bank	1162.40	8.84	12.27	4.20	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1082.80	7.99	22.27	1.29	
Eicher Motors	7943.00	5.19	40.67	0.93	
Bharat Elec	443.90	4.99	54.42	1.35	
L&T	4185.90	3.99	30.34	4.81	
Trent Ltd.	4265.60	3.25	94.05	0.18	
Titan	4275.80	2.42	79.65	1.50	
Asian Paints	2410.50	1.78	59.13	0.93	
UltraTech Cement	13029.00	1.56	50.10	1.31	
ONGC	276.35	1.49	8.12	0.91	
Bharti Airtel	2014.50	1.47	31.00	4.77	
Bajaj Finserv	2837.10	1.27	16.95	0.39	
Max Healthcare	1062.90	1.26	72.86	0.67	
Tata Steel	208.11	0.94	28.48	1.46	
Sun Pharma	1714.90	0.88	37.57	1.54	
Apollo Hospo	7539.00	0.72	58.10	0.66	
Or Reddys Lab	1274.90	0.61	19.27	0.66	
HDFC Life	702.70	0.38	80.08	0.64	
NestleIndia	1305.50	0.03	77.18	0.80	
Hindustan Unilever	40.20	DE*	—	0.03	
NTPC	368.25	-0.21	14.38	1.48	
JSW Steel	1247.90	-0.27	39.30	1.00	
SBI Life	2022.10	-0.42	79.65	0.77	
TataConsumerProduct	1149.30	-0.47	77.29	0.64	
Hindalco	964.40	-0.49	12.20	1.11	
PowerGrid Corp	293.90	-0.55	17.61	1.13	
Reliance PV	383.45	-0.57	52.14	0.68	
Grasim Ind	297.55	-0.59	21.09	0.39	
Bajaj Auto	9840.00	-0.72	30.93	0.93	
Adani Enter	2211.80	-1.29	18.06	4.09	
IntGlobalEvi	4982.80	-1.54	59.99	0.96	
Adani Ports	1543.70	-1.57	28.46	0.97	
ITC	317.45	-1.69	19.21	2.60	
Financial Services Ltd.	267.55	-1.98	105.92	0.75	
Coal India	419.15	-2.04	8.31	0.81	
Cipla	1330.00	-2.46	23.70	0.64	
Maruti Suzuki	15326.00	-2.47	32.27	1.71	
Eternal Ltd.	298.00	-4.25	1244.94	1.82	
Axis Bank	1340.00	-4.59	15.75	3.26	
Kotak Bank	426.25	-5.32	22.55	2.66	
Wipro	219.08	-6.72	17.23	0.53	
Hind Unilever	2409.70	-10.35	51.82	1.82	
Tech Mahindra	1536.60	-13.62	32.79	0.83	
M&M	3593.10	-16.01	28.81	2.73	
HCL Tech	1476.10	-17.47	24.39	3.32	
HDFC Bank	920.60	-21.80	18.29	1.97	
Reliance Ind	1448.90	-29.32	20.05	8.31	
TCS	2750.10	-35.76	20.75	2.39	
Infosys	1386.00	-65.98	20.07	4.13	

Pts: Impact on index movement
DE: Demerged Entity

Nifty Next 50 Movers					▼ 300.45 pts.
	Close(%)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Samvardmotheresoninternat	132.74	34.25	38.50	2.53	
Britannia Ind	6102.00	29.37	60.82	3.09	
Tata Power	380.55	24.69	24.28	2.74	
Siemens Energy India .	2731.30	17.33	84.01	1.04	
Zydlusifsciences	920.95	17.00	18.44	0.99	
Pidlifind	1497.40	16.12	65.85	2.00	
Hindustanaeronautics	4158.90	14.74	32.84	3.39	
Jindal Steel	1203.40	14.46	60.89	1.93	
Havells	1400.50	12.64	59.24	1.52	
Indian Hotels Co.	712.00	11.73	55.00	2.68	
Tvs Motor Cmp .	3681.20	11.34	60.39	3.31	
Cholamandalamin&fin	1731.80	11.17	30.15	3.14	
Vedanta	702.75	8.14	16.59	5.12	
Torrent Pharma	4077.20	6.43	64.48	1.83	
United Spirits	1417.40	3.99	59.94	1.80	
Lic	880.95	3.76	10.90	0.84	
Adanigenenergy	997.65	2.67	88.54	1.31	
Gail (India)	163.72	2.02	12.51	1.90	
Siemens	3148.50	-0.82	70.72	2.19	
Cg Power & Ind Sol	685.10	-1.03	97.25	2.02	
Bosch	36495.00	-1.95	39.05	1.36	
Bajaj Housing Finance .	90.39	-2.02	30.40	0.36	
Magazoon Dock	2414.90	-3.58	40.48	0.79	
Solar Industries	13391.00	-3.95	79.37	1.40	
Indian Railway Finance Corp	113.53	-4.29	21.17	0.87	
Jsw Energy .	479.50	-4.59	32.19	1.10	
Hyundai Motor India .	2177.50	-4.71	30.56	1.33	
Varun Beverages	455.70	-4.93	50.33	2.68	
Godrej Consumer	1204.30	-5.19	67.65	2.08	
Abb India	5788.50	-5.82	0.00	1.30	
Hindus Zinc	623.70	-6.31	22.33	1.16	
Canara Bank	144.81	-7.08	7.13	2.10	
Bank Of Baroda	289.85	-7.51	7.63	2.31	
Macrotech Developers .	1084.85	-8.48	32.39	1.31	
icici Lombard Gic	1919.80	-8.64	34.14	1.99	
Bajaj Holdings	1180.40	-9.22	13.71	2.05	
Adani Energy Solutions .	1022.80	-11.45	51.54	1.52	
Rural Elec	350.70	-12.18	5.36	1.88	
Adani Power .	149.79	-13.26	25.57	2.54	
Ambuja Cements	532.85	-15.37	26.76	2.39	
Avenuesuper	3963.00	-17.98	90.00	2.50	
Shree Cement	2649.00	-18.66	52.91	1.51	
Punjab Nat Bank	120.96	-20.17	7.78	1.79	
Power Finance	410.55	-23.15	4.06	2.57	
Info Edge I	1149.30	-25.11	44.98	1.92	
Indian Oilcorp	178.11	-36.87	6.82	2.86	
Dif	651.80	-39.97	36.43	1.79	
Bpcl	377.70	-57.57	6.66	3.14	
Divis Lab	6155.00	-65.81	66.07	3.37	
Limtindree	521.50	-74.58	32.71	2.07	

CM
YK

Agnikul to help NeevCloud host data centre in space

NOVEL IDEA. Will use rocket upper stage to house data centre

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

As AI workloads soar and the need for data centres increases, an Indian space tech start-up is gearing up to facilitate a data centre (DC) in space.

Agnikul Cosmos now has the capabilities to host space-based data centres via its extendable upper stage, and in its first commercial agreement, Agnikul is partnering with cloud company NeevCloud to help the latter host its AI SuperCloud platform in space, *businessline* has learnt.

“We are providing a platform to host our partner entity’s data centre in orbit in the upper stage. This is a natural extension of our rocket, which has been designed to function in orbit in the upper stage after you eject a satellite. We are now going to work with NeevCloud to repurpose it to host their DC,” Srinath Ravichandran, Co-founder and CEO, Agnikul Cosmos, told *businessline*.

Narendra Sen, Founder & CEO of NeevCloud, said in a statement: “To truly democratise AI, we must decouple it from terrestrial limitations. By partnering with Agnikul, we are taking our AI SuperCloud to the ultimate orbit edge — Space.”

The initiative will place high-performance AI inference nodes directly into Low Earth Orbit (LEO), enabling secure, ultra-low-latency intelligence for billions of



Srinath Ravichandran (left), Co-founder & CEO of Agnikul Cosmos, and Moin SPM, Co-founder & COO

users and critical industries worldwide, the companies said.

PIONEERING MOVE
NeevCloud is an Indian entity empowering AI firms globally by providing cloud AI solutions by leveraging GPU technology.

Agnikul and NeevCloud have been in discussions to host the latter’s payload in space and, in that process, arrived at this decision to align to host a DC in space, Ravichandran explained.

Globally, technology companies are exploring the launch of data centres into orbit to overcome Earth’s power and cooling constraints. Elon Musk’s SpaceX is among the companies working on this.

In India, Agnikul’s capability to host DCs in the upper stage may be the first instance of a rocket company doing it.

Agnikul’s architecture is such that the upper stage of their rocket can extend its life in orbit after a satellite is

launched. With the patented technology in place, the start-up has now found an application in repurposing it to host DCs in space.

Agnikul targets a fleet of assets in orbit with AI stacks that form modular Space Data Centre Modules (SD-CMs). The alliance will help NeevCloud to expand its network to 600+ orbital edge data centres over 3 years.

THE RIGHT SPACE
In terms of timeline, Agnikul aims to demonstrate a basic prototype of this DC module on a test basis in their upcoming launch in the coming months and then go for an actual launch by 2027. Following successful validation, NeevCloud will scale the network of 600+ Orbital edge data centres over the next three years.

The idea of setting up a DC in space is getting a lot of interest globally, as space will address the aspect of energy availability, environmental sustainability, and the ability to cool with less cost.

Extending the spent upper stages of rockets reduces potential space debris while maximising the utility of every launch. Solar power can also help address the power consumption for the data centre, Agnikul said.

The mass of the satellite and other level specs are all in place and both companies will now work to customise our platforms so that it works well to host a DC in space, Ravichandran added.

BharatNet has reached 2.14 lakh gram panchayats till now: Scindia

Our Bureau
New Delhi



Union Minister for Communications Jyotiraditya M Scindia ANI

The government on Thursday said that under BharatNet, the flagship rural broadband connectivity programme, optical fibre cable is being laid across 2.56 lakh gram panchayats (GPs) at an investment of around ₹42,000 crore. Over 2.14 lakh GPs have already been made service-ready in phases-I and -II.

“The Amended BharatNet programme, with a total outlay of around \$16.9 billion, has become the world’s largest rural connectivity initiative,” said Minister for Communications Jyotiraditya M Scindia while replying to questions in Parliament on Thursday.

NETWORK RELIABILITY

The Minister informed that the network architecture is being upgraded from a line topology to a ring topology model. If connectivity is disrupted from one direction, services will continue uninterrupted from the other, thereby significantly enhancing network reliability and uptime.

ROAD BLOCKS

Scindia said that across the country, the average disposal time for right of way (RoW) applications has been reduced from 455 days to just 30.4 days and out of 36 States and Union Territories, 33 have operationalised the RoW portal. Tamil Nadu is among the three States

where it has not yet been implemented, he added.

In Tamil Nadu, the average RoW disposal time is 85 days. The Minister stated that he had written multiple letters to the Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu, urging the implementation of the RoW portal and expediting approvals in the larger public interest.

CYBER SECURITY

Meanwhile, regarding the Digital Intelligence Platform (DIP), a secure online platform, Scindia said more than 1,200 organisations have been onboarded, including central security agencies, police departments of 36 States and UTs, the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C), banks, Unified Payments Interface (UPI) service providers, payment system operators, and telecom service providers.

He informed that over 88-lakh suspicious connections have been disconnected and ₹1,400 crore in potential frauds have been prevented through risk-based interventions and there are nearly 99 per cent reduction in spoofed calls achieved through advanced monitoring systems.

Surat-based Acutaas subsidiary acquires 75% stake in South Korea’s Indichem

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

Acutaas Advance Material Ltd (formerly Baba Advance Materials Ltd), a wholly-owned subsidiary of Surat-based Acutaas Chemicals, has completed the acquisition of a 75 per cent controlling stake in the South Korea-based Indichem Inc, marking its formal entry into the semiconductor chemicals manufacturing space in the country.

“We would like to inform that Acutaas Advance Material Ltd (erstwhile Baba Advance Materials Ltd), a wholly owned subsidiary of Acutaas Chemicals Ltd, has acquired a 75 per cent of shareholding stake in the joint venture company, Indichem Inc. The information of the same has been received today to the company. Pursuant to this, Indichem Inc has become a step down subsidiary of the company,” the company

stated on Wednesday. Indichem Inc, incorporated in 2025, operates in the semiconductor chemicals industry, a segment witnessing strong global demand amid capacity expansion in chip manufacturing.

The transaction was executed through a cash purchase of 3,00,000 shares at a par value of KRW 500 per share plus applicable share premium.

“The construction and capex work of Indichem Inc’s manufacturing plant in South Korea is in progress and is slated to be commissioned by the end of the current calendar year,” it added.

MORE INVESTMENTS

Commenting on the venture, Naresh Patel, CMD of Acutaas Chemicals, told investors earlier this month that the company is witnessing encouraging traction from clients in Indichem, with initial discussions already un-

derway with multiple potential customers in South Korea, Japan and Taiwan.

In the same earnings call, Abhishek Patel, Vice President (Strategy) of Acutaas Chemicals, highlighted the scale of the investment and future revenue prospects.

“Apart from this, another major cash outlay during the year will be our investment in South Korea joint venture, Indichem. Till now, we have invested close to ₹130 crore in this joint venture. The total investment we announced for this joint venture was around ₹200 crore,” Patel said.

“We have sufficient cash on hand as well as strong cash flow generation to fund this cash outlay. For the Indichem project, as I mentioned, our plant — capex should be completed by this calendar year, year 2026, and from next calendar year onwards, we should see revenue coming in this business,” the Vice-President added.

Biological E. gets full WHO approval for polio vaccine nOPV2

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

Biological E. Ltd (BE), a Hyderabad-based pharmaceuticals and biologics company, has received the final permission for its polio vaccine from the World Health Organisation.

Now, the company can handle the entire vaccine

manufacturing process in-house.

This is an upgrade from the phase-I approval received in June 2024, which only allowed Biological E. to manufacture the final vaccine product using materials supplied by other companies.

“The WHO granted us the phase-II pre-qualifica-

tion for our novel oral polio vaccine type 2 (nOPV2). It covers both drug substance and drug product manufactured at BE, completing the full manufacturing chain for the vaccine at a single integrated site,” a company statement said.

Biological E. has already produced and delivered over 700 million doses of

nOPV2 to various countries that are running campaigns to stop outbreaks of the circulating vaccine-derived poliovirus.

“When polio outbreaks occur, response time and vaccine availability determine how quickly transmission can be stopped. nOPV2 has been deployed in over a billion doses globally be-

cause it is designed for outbreak control with improved genetic stability,” Mahima Datla, MD, Biological E. Ltd, said.

“With this, global supply becomes more resilient and more responsive. That matters because every delay in outbreak response carries real risk for children and communities,” she said.

Godrej Industries Limited

CIN : L24241MH1988PLC097781

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website : www.godrejindustries.com, Email Id: investor@godrejinds.com

EXTRACT OF UNAUDITED CONSOLIDATED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED AND NINE MONTHS ENDED DECEMBER 31, 2025						
(Amounts in ₹ Crore)						
Particulars	Quarter Ended			Nine Months Ended		Year Ended
	31-Dec-25 Unaudited	30-Sep-25 Unaudited	31-Dec-24 Unaudited	31-Dec-25 Unaudited	31-Dec-24 Unaudited	31-Mar-25 Audited
Total Income from Operations	5,051.19	5,032.14	4,824.83	14,543.13	13,877.72	19,657.41
Net Profit for the period before Share of Profit of Equity Accounted Investees, Exceptional Items and Tax	438.36	686.83	303.01	2,091.26	1,418.04	1,978.54
Net Profit after Tax	352.68	492.95	312.40	1,570.99	1,442.10	1,858.24
Net Profit After Tax attributable to the owners of the Company	204.55	242.47	188.20	796.25	798.29	981.38
Total Comprehensive Income for the period (Comprising Profit) for the period (after tax) &						
Other Comprehensive Income (after tax) attributable to the owners of the Company	247.88	295.75	204.92	909.62	849.70	995.53
Paid-up Equity Share Capital (Face value - ₹1 per share)	33.68	33.68	33.68	33.68	33.68	33.68
Reserves excluding Revaluation Reserve as shown in the audited Balance Sheet						10,117.86
Net worth	10,629.91	10,399.88	10,113.33	10,629.91	10,113.33	10,151.54
Debt/Equity Ratio	1.65	1.55	1.24	1.65	1.24	1.22
Debt Service Coverage Ratio	1.62	1.63	1.90	1.55	1.52	1.69
Interest Service Coverage Ratio	2.09	2.63	2.11	2.64	2.64	2.59
Earnings per share (In ₹) (Not Annualised)						
(a) Basic	6.07	7.20	5.59	23.64	23.71	29.14
(b) Diluted	6.08	7.19	5.59	23.64	23.70	29.13

Key numbers of Unaudited Standalone Financial Results						
(Amounts in ₹ Crore)						
Particulars	Quarter Ended			Nine Months Ended		Year Ended
	31-Dec-25 Unaudited	30-Sep-25 Unaudited	31-Dec-24 Unaudited	31-Dec-25 Unaudited	31-Dec-24 Unaudited	31-Mar-25 Audited
Turnover (Net Sales)	1,226.97	1,330.26	1,022.89	3,575.52	3,084.80	4,171.21
Profit / (Loss) Before Exceptional Items and Tax	(12.84)	99.02	0.20	56.19	257.99	190.17
Profit / (Loss) After Tax	(21.05)	99.02	0.20	47.98	257.99	189.67
Total Comprehensive Income for the period (Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) & Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)	(20.33)	98.90	0.07	47.54	257.61	185.53
Paid up Equity Share Capital	33.68	33.68	33.68	33.68	33.68	33.68
Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserves)	1,721.99	1,741.33	1,742.72	1,721.99	1,742.72	1,671.47
Capital Redemption Reserve	31.46	31.46	31.46	31.46	31.46	31.46
Debenture Redemption Reserve	-	-	-	-	-	-
Securities Premium	933.33	933.20	930.38	933.33	930.38	930.38
Net worth	1,755.67	1,775.01	1,776.40	1,755.67	1,776.40	1,705.15
Outstanding Net Debt	10,130.84	9,713.37	9,184.28	10,130.84	9,184.28	9,033.17
Debt/Equity Ratio	5.77	5.47	5.17	5.77	5.17	5.30
Debt Service Coverage Ratio	0.39	1.46	0.91	0.42	0.60	0.60
Interest Service Coverage Ratio	1.02	1.62	1.15	1.20	1.64	1.40
Earning per Equity Share (EPS):-						
Basic EPS	(0.62)	2.94	0.01	1.43	7.66	5.63
Diluted EPS	(0.63)	2.94	0.01	1.42	7.66	5.63

Notes:

1) The above Statement of unaudited financial results which are published in accordance with Regulations 33 and 52 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations & Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, as amended, have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors at their meetings held on February 11, 2026. The financial results are in accordance with the Indian Accounting Standards (Ind-AS) as prescribed under Section 133 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with the relevant rules thereunder. The above results have been reviewed by the Statutory Auditors of the Company who have expressed an unmodified review conclusion vide their review reports thereon.

2) The above is an extract of the detailed format of the Quarterly Financial Results filed with Stock Exchanges under Regulations 33 and 52 of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements), 2015. The full format of the Quarterly Financial Results are available on the Stock Exchanges websites i.e., National Stock Exchange of India Limited (URL: www.nseindia.com) and BSE India Limited (URL: www.bseindia.com) and on the Company's website (URL: <https://www.godrejindustries.com/>). The same can also be accessed by scanning the QR Code provided below.

3) On November 21, 2025 the Government of India notified four Labour Codes - the Code on Wages, 2019, the Industrial Relations Code, 2020, the Code on Social Security, 2020, and the Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions Code, 2020 - consolidating 29 existing labour laws. The corresponding detailed Rules are yet to be notified. The Company/Group has assessed and disclosed the incremental impact of these changes basis actuarial valuation and management estimates and have accounted an additional gratuity and leave benefits liability of ₹63.77 crore and ₹8.21 crore in the Consolidated and Standalone Financial results respectively for the quarter and nine months ended December 31, 2025, as an Exceptional item. The Company will monitor the developments and update the estimates when further clarifications/ Rules are notified.

4) The Company has, on January 5, 2026, incorporated a wholly owned subsidiary under the name Godrej Investment Limited, with an investment of ₹3,862.70 crores. Subsequently, on January 28, 2026, the Company effected the divestment and transfer of its entire equity holding in Godrej Capital Limited, a subsidiary, to Godrej Investment Limited at a consideration of ₹3,862.69 crore. Pursuant to the aforesaid transaction, and with effect from January 28, 2026, Godrej Capital Limited has ceased to be a direct subsidiary of the Company and has become a step-down subsidiary through its holding under Godrej Investment Limited. This transaction is classified as a non-adjusting event in accordance with Ind AS 10 — Events after the Reporting Period, and does not have any impact on the financial results of the quarter and nine months ended December 31, 2025.

Place: Mumbai
Date : February 11, 2026

**By Order of the Board
For Godrej Industries Limited**

**N. B. Godrej
Chairman & Managing Director
DIN: 00066195**

QUICKLY.

MoD inks deal with HAL for eight Dornier aircraft



New Delhi: The Ministry of Defence has signed a contract with Hindustan Aeronautics Ltd to acquire eight Dornier 228 aircraft, along with operational role equipment for the Indian Coast Guard at a cost of ₹2,312 crore, under the Buy (Indian) category. This is part of the capacity building exercise by the Coast Guard which aims to increase its fleet of air assets from existing 80, which includes aircraft and choppers, to 100 by 2030. HAL's Kanpur-based Transport Aircraft Division inked the contract in the presence of Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh in Delhi. **OUR BUREAU**

Matrimony.com Q3 PAT down 17% at ₹8.3 crore



Chennai: Online matrimony company Matrimony.com reported a 1.8 per cent fall in revenue in the quarter ended December 2025 at ₹113.2 crore against ₹111.4 crore in the same quarter last year. The company's PAT stood at ₹8.3 crore, a 17 per cent decline from the ₹10 crore posted in the same quarter previous year. Billings increased 7.7 per cent to ₹118 crore. During the quarter, the company initiated a share buyback amounting to ₹58.50 crore, which is expected to be completed by Q4 FY26. **OUR BUREAU**

Farmers, trade unions protest against labour codes, US trade deal

UP IN ARMS. Several Opposition parties back bandh; protesters call to scrap VB-G-RAM G Act, draft Seed Bill

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Trade unions and farmer groups staged a nationwide one-day strike against the implementation of labour codes and the proposed US trade deal, with reports indicating a mixed response across States. The joint platform of Central Trade Unions (CTUs) and independent sectoral federations termed the Bharat Bandh a “grand success” in a joint statement. Protesters hit the streets with banners and slogans, calling the labour codes “pro-corporate” and a “direct attack on workers’ rights”, and describing the trade deal as a “total sur-

render” to the US. They also demanded withdrawal of the draft Seed Bill, the Electricity Amendment Bill and the proposed SHANTI Act, alleging that it would open nuclear power generation to private and foreign players driven by profit.

OTHER DEMANDS Among other demands were restoration of MGNREGA, scrapping of the Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act, 2025, reversal of 100 per cent FDI in insurance, withdrawal of the Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan Bill, 2025, and filling vacant government posts. The Congress and several Opposition parties backed



UNITED FRONT. Members of various trade unions raising slogans during a nationwide strike against the Centre's policies, in Gurugram, Haryana, on Thursday **PTI**

the bandh. Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi said farmers fear that trade agreements would “strike a blow to their livelihood.” However, Congress MP

Shashi Tharoor criticised “coercive disruptions” in Kerala, remarking that the Bharat Bandh had effectively become a “Kerala Bandh.” While supporting the right to protest, he opposed “mil-

itant unionism” that hampers industrial growth.

WIDESPREAD ACTIVITY According to the joint platform, strike actions and mobilisations were organised in over 600 districts.

Students and youth joined protests in several places, raising slogans on education and employment. Women workers from ICDS, ASHA, mid-day meal schemes, *beedi*, domestic work and other unorganised sectors led road and rail blockades in some areas. E-rickshaw drivers, auto and taxi unions also participated in parts of the country.

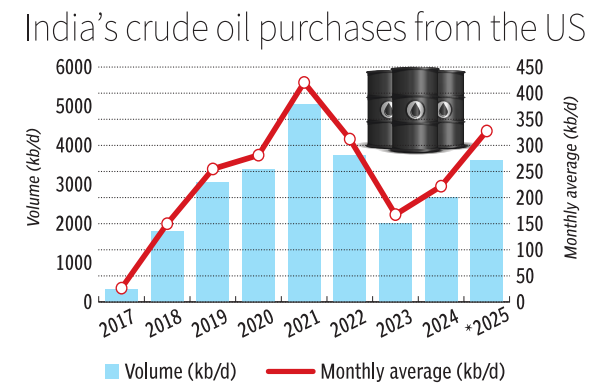
In Maharashtra, the strike drew a mixed response, with business largely continuing amid sporadic disruptions.

Import of US crude in 2025 may be 2nd highest on record

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Amid pressure from the US on India to stop Russian crude oil imports, Washington's exports of the geopolitically-sensitive commodity to New Delhi are already set to hit the second-highest on record in CY2025.

According to the latest data from the US Energy Information Administration (EIA), cumulative US crude oil exports to India stood around 3,603 thousand barrels per day (kb/d) during the January-November 2025 period, averaging at roughly 327.55 kb/d per month. The export numbers for December 2025 are yet to be updated. Currently, the 2025 ex-



port volumes are the third-highest on record, after CY2021 (5,046 kb/d) and CY2022 (3,745 kb/d).

Refiners and analysts, however, said India has upped its crude oil purchases

from the US, and this year's numbers are expected to surpass the volume recorded in 2022.

RIISING US SHARE The rising US share carries

strategic value and supports diversification strategies. Higher energy imports from Washington will help narrow India's trade deficit with the US and fit into New Delhi's broader strategy of diversifying energy supply chains. The increase in crude trade also reinforces energy co-operation between New Delhi and Washington.

However, India's purchases of US crude oil, particularly WTI Midland and Eagle Ford grades, have limited upside. For instance, WTI Midland, a light (API 40-42), naphtha-rich crude, yields fewer middle distillates (diesel) than the medium and heavy sours Indian refineries are optimised for.

US crude grades may replace some volumes from West Africa, such as Nigeria,

which supplies light sweet crudes such as Bonny Light. The longer voyage time (45-55 days) and higher freight costs compared with Middle Eastern and African grades curb competitiveness.

The elevated US presence in India's crude basket underscores the deepening strategic energy alignment between the two countries and supports India's broader diversification strategy balancing security, economics and geopolitics.

Arvind SmartSpaces unveils ₹9,500 cr project pipeline across Gujarat, Maharashtra & Karnataka

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

Arvind SmartSpaces Ltd is preparing to roll out ₹9,500 crore worth of yet-to-be-launched projects across Gujarat, Maharashtra and Karnataka over the next 4-5 years, with a significant portion expected to hit the market in the next 18 months, even as the broader residential cycle shows signs of stabilising.

Detailing the upcoming inventory, the company stated that Gujarat with ₹5,077 crore worth of yet to be launched projects occupy the biggest pie, followed by Karnataka and Maharashtra where ₹2,899 crore and ₹1,520 crore worth of projects are planned respectively.

“Most of these projects are work in progress. Some of these are very large projects and so there is a possibility that some of the phases

The company intends to launch ₹1,500 crore worth of projects in the ongoing fourth quarter of FY26

of these projects will come in 1-1.5 years. But largely, when you look at that kind of inventory, we are looking to monetise most of the assets over the next 4-5 years — from the launch, selling and construction perspective. From an inventory point of view, this is quite Ahmedabad-heavy. But over 18 months, we expect most of this inventory to start coming into the market,” Priyansh Kapoor, MD & CEO, told investors on Wednesday.

LAUNCH TARGETS MISS Despite the strong pipeline visibility, the company has fallen short of its launch

guidance for the current financial year, largely due to slower-than-anticipated approvals and phased project rollouts.

“We were aiming for ₹2,500 crore worth of launches for the year and we have done only ₹500 crore. We should have done at least ₹2,000 crore of inventory in the last quarter. In Bengaluru, out of the two projects that we were thinking we will get in the current year, we will probably get one of those. That is why our current estimate is less on the approval front. Second, we had also mentioned that the industrial project will come in parts and Vadodara we are doing in phases,” Kapoor said, adding that the company intends to launch ₹1,500 crore worth of projects in the ongoing fourth quarter of FY26.

Kapoor indicated that the residential market has entered a phase of stabilisation after the strong mo-

mentum seen in the previous financial year. The company's focus segments, he said, are performing well, and management does not see any immediate cause for concern given the portfolio mix and product positioning. He added that regulatory changes in Karnataka have contributed to slower approvals.

NEW LAUNCHES IN Q4 In the March quarter, Arvind SmartSpaces is looking to step up activity with ₹1,500 crore worth of launches. This includes the first phase of its Vadodara project — entailing around ₹400 crore of inventory as part of a larger ₹700 crore development — as well as the phase-1 launch of its industrial project in Ahmedabad.

The industrial development has a total project cost of about ₹1,500 crore, with the initial phase pegged at roughly ₹600-650 crore of inventory.

Welspun Living Q3 profit plummets 99.8% on weak revenues

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

Gujarat-based Welspun Living Ltd reported a steep 99.8 per cent decline in consolidated net profit for the third quarter of FY26, dragged by subdued demand in its home textiles and flooring segments. Profit attributable to the owners fell to ₹0.21 crore, down from ₹120.83 crore in the same quarter last year. Revenue from operations was down 9 per cent to ₹2,262 crore. The home textiles segment saw a 4.7 per cent drop, while the flooring business recorded a sharper decline of 20.4 per cent.

On the corporate front, the board has approved the redemption of 13,89,575 zero per cent Redeemable Preference Shares at an issue price of ₹1,000 per share, issued by Welspun Global Brands Ltd, a subsidiary of the company.



VAMSHI RUBBER LIMITED

CIN: L25100TG1993PLC016634

Regd. Office: VAMSHI HOUSE, Plot No. 41,
Jayabheri Enclave, Gachibowli, Hyderabad-500032, Telangana

E-Mail: info@vamshirubber.org, Website: www.vamshirubber.org

EXTRACT FROM THE UN-AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR
THE QUARTER ENDED 31ST DECEMBER, 2025

(RS. IN LAKHS)

Sr. No.	PARTICULARS	QUARTER ENDED 31-12-2025 Unaudited (Ind AS)	QUARTER ENDED 31-12-2024 Unaudited (Ind AS)	Year Ended 31-03-2025 Audited (Ind AS)
1.	Total Income from operations	1,895.93	2,052.12	8,619.38
2.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	8.23	10.81	88.66
3.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before Tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	8.23	10.81	85.24
4.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after Tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	11.68	9.12	67.64
5.	Total Comprehensive Income for the period (comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (After tax)	15.92	9.12	84.60
6.	Equity Share Capital	420.68	420.68	420.68
7.	Reserves excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet of the previous year	1,119.19	992.77	1,032.85
8.	Earning Per Share (after extraordinary items) (of Rs.10/- each)			
	(a) Basic (in Rs.)	0.38	0.22	2.01
	(b) Diluted (in Rs.)	0.38	0.22	2.01

NOTE:

1) The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulations 2015. The full format of the Quarterly Financial Results are available on the Stock Exchanges websites, www.bseindia.com and website of the Company www.vamshirubber.org

2) The Company has adopted Indian Accounting Standards under Section 133 of the Companies Act, 2013 (Ind AS) from 1st April, 2017.

By the Order of the Board
for Vamshi Rubber Limited

Sd/-

(M.RAMESH REDDY)

Chairman & CFO

DIN: 00025101

Place: Hyderabad

Date: 12-02-2026

CEETA INDUSTRIES LIMITED				
(CIN: L15100KA1984PLC021494)				
Regd. Office: Plot No. 34-38, KIADB Industrial Area, Sathyamangala, Tumkur-572 104, Karnataka.				
Ph.: 91-816-2970 239; Email: kolkata@ceeta.com; Website: www.ceeta.com				
EXTRACT OF UNAUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE THIRD QUARTER AND NINE MONTH ENDED DECEMBER 31, 2025 (Rs. in Lakhs)				
Sl. No.	Particulars	Quarter ended 31.12.2025 (Unaudited)	Nine month ended 31.12.2025 (Unaudited)	Corresponding Quarter ended 31.12.2024 (Unaudited)
1	Total income from operations	692.10	1,811.81	670.19
2	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	8.49	57.85	(7.37)
3	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	8.49	57.85	(7.37)
4	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	9.95	42.69	5.81
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit/(Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	0.99	2.86	0.58
6	Equity Share Capital	145.02	145.02	145.02
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet of previous year	-	-	-
8	Earning Per Share (of Re.1/-each)(for continuing and discontinued operations) - Basic & Diluted	0.07	0.29	0.04
Notes:				
1) The above results have been reviewed by Audit Committee and subsequently approved and taken on record by the Board of Directors at its meeting held on February 12, 2026. The Statutory Auditors of the Company have conducted limited review on these results for the third quarter and nine month ended December 31, 2025.				
2) The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 for the third quarter and nine month ended December 31, 2025. The full format of the Quarterly Financial Results are available on the website of the Stock Exchange(s) where the Company is listed i.e. www.bseindia.com and Company's website at https://ceeta.com/quarterly-report. The same can also be accessed by scanning the QR Code.				
For Ceeta Industries Ltd.		Sd/-		
K.M. Poddar		Managing Director (DIN 00028012)		
Place: Kolkata		Date: 12.02.2026		

India contributed 42% of fresh pipeline for Marriott in 2025

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

India was among the top-performing regions for Marriott International in the Asia-Pacific (excluding China), accounting for 42 per cent of signed rooms in 2025.

The US-headquartered hotel chain said the region saw its third consecutive year of record growth with 187 deals, representing a pipeline of 28,000 rooms. This was 32 per cent higher year-on-year.

The top five growth markets in the Asia-Pacific (excluding China) with the highest number of signings in 2025 were India, Thailand, Vietnam, Malaysia and Japan. India saw the most sign-



India saw the most signings, with 99 deals, representing over 12,000 rooms

ings, with a record 99 deals, representing over 12,000 rooms.

Last year, the chain affiliated with The Fern brand in India, resulting in the conversion of 26 existing prop-

erties under the new Series by Marriott brand.

The deal led to the conversion of 26 hotels to the brand in a single day, adding 1,900 rooms to its portfolio overnight.

“SCALE WITH PURPOSE” “Our record performance in 2025 underscores the strength of Marriott's growth engine across the region, and the enduring confidence our hotel owners place in our brands and operating platform. Sustained intra-regional and international travel demand and a diversified portfolio have enabled us to add scale with purpose,” said Rajeev Menon, President, Asia-Pacific (excluding China), Marriott International.

E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE					
"Sale of Asset on standalone basis" of					
Agarwal Realty Developers Private Limited (In Liquidation)					
Regd. Office: H.No.3-6-687, Flat No.303, Street No.11, Himayat Nagar, Hyderabad-500029.					
Sale will be performed by the undersigned through E-Auction platform:					
https://bbi.baanknet.com/eauction-ibbi/home					
					(Rs in lakhs)
No.	Asset Particulars / Particulars	Reserve Price	EMD Amt.	Incremental Bid	Net Worth
1.	Lot No.1: Immovable property / Commercial Space of 3702 sqft of carpet area in Pinnacle Corporate Park, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (East), Mumbai	1103.00	110.00	10.00	221.00
2.	Lot No.2: Actionable claim of Rs.271.47 lakhs	244.30	24.42	1.00	48.90
3.	Lot No.3: Actionable claim of Rs.72.75 lakhs	65.48	6.54	1.00	13.10
4.	Last Date for Submission of EMD for all lots	18.03.2026			
5.	Time & Date of E-Auction (For all lots in sequence)	20.03.2026 From 11.00 am to 3.30 pm			
6.	For other details Contact: Mr. Murali Mohan Chevuturi , Liquidator, Mobile: No.8978844588, or through email - liquidation.agarwal@gmail.com or Log on to: https://bbi.baanknet.com/eauction-ibbi/home				
Date: 13.02.2026		Sd/- Mr.Murali Mohan Chevuturi			
Place: Hyderabad		Liquidator			

CORRIGENDUM TO 15TH SALE NOTICE	
This is with reference to the 15th Sale Notice published on 24th January 2026 in Business Line (All India Editions) and Eenadu (All Telangana Editions) regarding the sale of assets of M/s Butta Infrastructure Private Limited (in Liquidation).	
Pursuant to the Order dated 10.02.2026 passed by the Hon'ble National Company Law Tribunal, Hyderabad Bench-I in IA (IBC) 1473/2025 in CP (IB) No. 3257/HDB/2020, the E-Auction scheduled to be held on 16.02.2026 stands kept in abeyance until further orders of the Hon'ble Tribunal.	
For further details, please contact the Liquidator.	
Sd/- Gonugunta Murali	
Liquidator	
M/s. Butta Infrastructure Private Limited	
IBBI Reg. No.:IBBI/IPA-001/IP-P00654/2017-18/11139	
AFA valid till 31-12-2026	
Email ID:buttainfra@ic@gmail.com	
Contact No.:91 9884504060	
Date: 12-02-2026	
Place: Hyderabad	



the falsification of documents, among others. These instances relate to the period between 2022 and 2025.

FIVE CATEGORIES

Per a complaint by the petitioner on July 23, 2025, the allegations are categorised into five categories of irregularities in the Talabira Thermal Power Project in Odisha, where a contract worth ₹137 crore was awarded to RSB Projects Pvt Ltd.

The other related to misconduct allegations around the construction of integrated township. The third instance involves certain irregularities in the sale and transport of Pond Ash. Misuse of CSR funds, and use of a purportedly forged authorisation letter in dealings with EXIM Bank, are also alleged.

The complaint was forwarded within the CBI and the petitioner was contacted for further details, but no FIR was registered, following which the petitioner approached the High Court.

The CBI defended its refusal to register an FIR by arguing that the petitioner's complaint consisted of vague and unverified allegations unsupported by any concrete evidence.

QUICKLY.

Gold eases as strong jobs data dims rate cut hopes



Gold prices ticked lower on Thursday after unexpectedly strong US jobs data for January tempered expectations of more near-term interest rate cuts by the Federal Reserve. Spot gold edged 0.3 per cent lower to \$5,062.83 per ounce by 1159 GMT. US gold futures for April delivery fell 0.3 per cent to \$5,084.30 per ounce. REUTERS

Palm oil ends lower on firmer ringgit

Jakarta: Malaysian palm oil futures closed lower for a third session on Thursday, as a slightly firmer ringgit added to the losses in the Dalian market and the lack of positive signals from a key market conference. The benchmark palm oil contract for April delivery on the Bursa Malaysia Derivatives Exchange fell 24 ringgit to 4,037 ringgit a tonne. REUTERS

Copper carried higher by improved sentiment



London: Copper prices rose on Thursday, supported by stronger appetite for risk across financial markets, while aluminium hit a near two-week high after Australia's South 32 confirmed that it would wind down a smelter in Mozambique. Benchmark 3-month copper on the LME added 0.5 per cent to \$13,237 a tonne in official open-outcry trading after edging up by 0.5 per cent on Wednesday. REUTERS

Coffee dips as supply outlook improves

GROWERS FEEL THE HEAT. Arabica parchment farmgate prices drop from ₹29,400 in November to ₹24,000

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

A sharp decline in the arabica coffee prices by about a fifth since the start of the 2025-26 crop year has triggered concerns among growers. Prices have declined by about 20 per cent for arabica, whereas the robusta prices have eased marginally since November last year, in line with the decline in global prices.

Improving supplies across all producing origins, especially the largest arabica producer Brazil, have resulted in the easing of prices in recent days.

“Prices have crashed from around \$3.75 per pound to below \$3 in a matter of months. These type of high price fluctuations cause undue uncertainty across the supply chain. Growers who need working capital are forced to sell at lower prices and buyers are not willing to take the risk of paying market prices, fearing a further fall in prices,” said Sahadev Balakrishna, Chairman, UPASI Coffee Committee. Farmgate prices of arabica

parchment, which hovered around the ₹29,000-₹29,400 range for a 50-kg bag during November are now around ₹24,000 levels for a 50-kg bag.

Similarly, arabica cherry, which ranged between ₹14,000 and ₹15,700 during early November, is now around ₹12,000 levels.

While robusta parchment prices have been largely steady at around ₹17,000 levels, the widely produced variety robusta parchment has eased by close to a tenth at around ₹9,650-₹10,500 levels from ₹10,700-₹11,600 levels.

LABOUR COSTS UP

“The sudden decline in price is going to impact big time for the growers because it’s a huge drop since the start of the season. Growers who have the ability to hold back are just watching, but a lot of people are trying to sell off because you need to run the show as the costs have gone up,” said M Salman Baseer, Chairman of the Karnataka Planters Association.

Meanwhile, labour costs are constantly rising irrespective of the huge fall in coffee prices, Balakrishna said. “Seeing the uptrend in prices, the labourers started demanding more per kg. We are already paying them good prices — beyond what the declared labour wages are,” Baseer said. The harvest of arabica is complete and of robusta should be over in the next couple of weeks. Praveen Kolimarla of Agrani Coffee and Commodities said the global coffee markets were showing early signs of supply-side easing, with Brazil and several other countries reporting stronger crops. Brazil’s latest estimates indicate a 17 per cent higher output, reinforcing expectations of a large harvest. Other key origins, including Vietnam, Indonesia, Uganda, Ethiopia, Central America and India, are also witnessing improved production, suggesting that farm-level adjustments are gradually lifting supply.



DIFFICULT TIME. Labour costs are constantly rising despite the huge fall in coffee prices REUTERS

ates indicate a 17 per cent higher output, reinforcing expectations of a large harvest. Other key origins, including Vietnam, Indonesia, Uganda, Ethiopia, Central America and India, are also witnessing improved production, suggesting that farm-level adjustments are gradually lifting supply.

DIFFERENT CYCLE

Despite the increase in visible supplies, the market remains inverted. Following the recent improvement in crop outlook, international coffee prices have begun to soften. While similar price corrections were seen last

year, the current cycle differs due to higher visible inventories. Market participants increasingly expect prices to trend lower in the near term, he said. Buying interest from global traders and roasters has picked up as prices ease. However, India remains an outlier. The differentials remain elevated, creating a price mismatch that is constraining trade volumes. Growers, meanwhile, appear in no rush to sell, adopting a wait-and-watch approach, Kolimarla said.

Pramod Somiah, a curer in Gonikoppa, said global coffee prices are being driven largely by terminal markets rather than physical trade dynamics. Despite a roughly 25 per cent correction in terminal prices, consumer prices have not declined proportionately, suggesting underlying demand remains intact. Growers facing price volatility may need to strengthen collective marketing through cooperatives and producer bodies to improve direct engagement with buyers and enhance price realisation, he said.

Natural rubber surges on supply crunch, strong demand

V Sajeev Kumar
Kochi

Natural rubber (NR) prices are on an upward trajectory due to supply shortage, owing to stoppage of tapping and increased demand. Ribbed Smoked Sheet (RSS) 4 prices are ruling at ₹210 per kg against ₹185 at the start of the year, an increase of 13 per cent.

Official sources said the overall outlook seems to be positive due to increased demand from the industry which, in all likelihood, is expected to retain the current momentum on domestic and

international fronts. India’s economic growth, which is also projected to be on the upward mode, is further providing hope for the growing fraternity in the country.

WEATHER WOES

Indian Sustainable Natural Rubber (ISNR) prices have increased to ₹188 per kg from ₹164.50. Latex prices are also on upward trend and Technically Specified Rubber (TSR) reached ₹139.50 per kg from the initial ₹129.45.

In the international markets, the situation is not different. In the Bangkok market, RSS 3 prices are currently ruling at ₹210.58 a



kg, up from ₹191.85 in the beginning of January. In Kuala Lumpur, the price of Standard Malaysian Rubber (SMR) 20 has reached ₹182.11 from ₹168.04 in the initial days of January. The rise can be attributed

to weather woes in the major South East Asian producing nations, leading to tightened NR supply, coupled with the strong industrial demand from China, the sources said.

CONTRIBUTING FACTOR

George Vally, President of the Indian Rubber Dealers Federation, told *businessline* that the recent statement by the Automotive Tyre Manufacturers Association on the severe shortage of NR in the domestic market is also a contributing factor, prompting farmers to hold back the stock for better rates. Simultaneously, the prices moved up both in the domestic and international markets.

However, Vally said with the start of summer rain and new leaves on trees after defoliation, farmers may start tapping again, which is expected to increase arrivals to the market.

Of the 5-6 new formulations IIL plans to launch, some of them would be a mixture of products in line with the latest trends. The company may have products from its research and development (R&D) centre through backward integration or in collaboration with its foreign partners.

“A lot of focus will be around providing the one-shot solution to the environment. This is total disease control, total pest control, or

IIL to launch formulations facility in Rajasthan

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Insecticides (India) Ltd will launch its formulation facility at Sotanala in Rajasthan’s Alwar district, with the first phase going on stream during the upcoming kharif season, said Rajesh Aggarwal, the company’s Managing Director.

The company plans to launch 5-6 formulations during the kharif season this year, while coming up with one-shot solutions that will cut the number of sprays on plants and at least double the number of demonstration plots in various villages.

The new plant, coinciding with the company’s silver jubilee celebrations, will come up in two phases. In the second phase, the technical synthesis unit will come up, he told *businessline*.

“We wish to provide momentum for our growth, launching new products, going aggressively into the market, and expansions will also come during this year,” Aggarwal said in an online interaction.

RAISING CAPACITY

In the first phase, the plant’s capacity will be 3,000 tonnes per annum. It will reach 10,000 tonnes in due course. “The formulation capacity might go up to 20,000 tonnes annually, including all types. This will help in augmenting our capacity by almost 15-20 per cent,” he said.

Of the 5-6 new formulations IIL plans to launch, some of them would be a mixture of products in line with the latest trends. The company may have products from its research and development (R&D) centre through backward integration or in collaboration with its foreign partners.

“A lot of focus will be around providing the one-shot solution to the environment. This is total disease control, total pest control, or



Rajesh Aggarwal, MD, Insecticides (India) Ltd

total weed control at one time. There is no definition of total, but in the field, it may end up saving 80-90 per cent of sprays,” said Aggarwal.

Stating that quite a few products are in the pipeline, he said IIL is in talks with a Japanese company, and the collaboration will be announced shortly.

The firm is increasing its partners, focussing to strengthen its current partnerships with companies such as Nissan.

With Nissan, IIL has launched half a dozen products, with the latest one coming this year. It has begun developing new formulations with Nissan’s products.

The company has filed the first invention application for 2026 with the Ministry of Agriculture, he said, adding that recently, it launched a product in association with US-based Corteva.

With IIL expanding continuously, it is trying to provide a complete crop solution to farmers. As part of this is has come up with IIL crop solution (ICS) plots of different crops. Currently, there are 13 such plots, 9 for rice and the rest for chilli and other crops.

Aggarwal said these plots are used to demonstrate to farmers on how they benefit from using lesser number of sprays and reduce input costs compared to traditional practices.

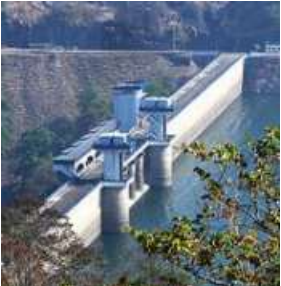
Storage in key reservoirs drops to 64% of capacity; 11 dams above 90%

Our Bureau
Chennai

Storage in India’s 166 major reservoirs dropped this week to 64 per cent of the capacity even as the level in 28 per cent of the 166 major dams was above 80 per cent.

According to the Central Water Commission (CWC), the storage in the major reservoirs was down to 118.140 billion cubic metres (BCM) against the 183.565 BCM capacity. This is over 10 per cent higher than a year ago and 25 per cent more than usual (last 10 years level).

While four reservoirs are brimming, the level in 11 was above 90 per cent and in 32, it was above 80 per cent. On the other hand, the storage in 30 reservoirs was below 50 per cent. The level in four of the five regions dropped below 70 per cent. In the western region, the storage was



75 per cent. Also, the storage in the southern region is below that of last year.

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), the country received 45 per cent deficient rainfall from January 1 to February 11. At least 76 per cent of the 727 districts in the country received deficient or no rainfall since the beginning of the year.

The CWC’s weekly reservoir data showed that in the 53 reservoirs of the western zone, the storage was 28.691 BCM of the 38.094 BCM ca-

capacity. Goa’s lone reservoir was filled to 77 per cent, while the level in Maharashtra and Gujarat was 75 per cent.

CENTRAL ZONE AT 75% Storage in the central zone’s 28 reservoirs was 75.3 per cent or 32.692 BCM of the 48.588 BCM capacity.

In the southern region, the level in the 47 reservoirs was 56.63 per cent (57.21 a year ago) or 31.307 BCM against the 55.288 BCM capacity.

In the northern region, the level in the 11 reservoirs was 60 per cent or 11.960 BCM of the 19.836 capacity BCM.

The 27 reservoirs in the eastern region were filled to 62 per cent of the 21.759 BCM capacity at 13.490 BCM.

With the IMD forecasting no rain over the next two weeks, the storage will likely drop further.

Go long if zinc breaks out of ₹332, stop-loss at ₹327

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl.research bureau

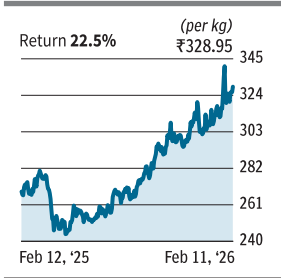
Zinc futures have seen some recovery over the past week. The February futures is now trading at ₹330 (per kg).

The price action of the contract since the beginning of February shows that it has developed some bullish bias after a brief period of consolidation.

COMMODITY CALL.

The chart shows that February futures has been forming lower highs over the past two weeks. But it is now facing resistance at ₹332.

A breakout of ₹332 could trigger a quick upswing to the ₹345-350 price region. But if zinc falls from the current level and slips below the support at ₹325, the bears could gain traction. A breach of ₹325 could open the door



for a decline to ₹318.

So, overall, the broader trend has been bullish and after a pause, the price action indicates that the bulls are gaining traction. But since there is a resistance ahead, traders ought to wait before pulling the trigger.

TRADE STRATEGY

Buy zinc if it breaks out of ₹332. Target and stop-loss can be ₹345 and ₹327, respectively. After initiating the trade, when the contract touches ₹340, revise the stop-loss to ₹332 so that the trade is protected.

Vedanta Aluminium boosts billet output to 8.30 lakh tonnes a year

Our Bureau
Chennai

Vedanta Aluminium has expanded the billet production capacity at its Jharsuguda plant in Odisha, the world’s largest aluminium facility, taking the total billet production capacity to 8,30,000 tonnes per year.

This will strengthen the company’s ability to supply high-quality products to customers worldwide, broaden its value-added product (VAP) portfolio, and reinforce its role in supporting India’s fast-growing extrusion and downstream sectors, a company statement said.

Vedanta Aluminum’s billets are key semi-finished products used in extrusion processes to create precision engineered profiles. These profiles support critical industries, including infrastructure, transportation,



renewable energy, electrical systems, consumer goods and packaging. Owing to aluminium’s high strength-to-weight ratio, recyclability and versatility, billets also play a vital role in enabling sustainable manufacturing and modern design solutions, it said.

The expansion adds 2,50,000 tonnes per annum of new capacity to the existing 5,80,000 tonnes a year billet infrastructure.

VALUE-ADDITION

This positions Jharsuguda among the largest aluminium billet production sites globally. The facility is

equipped with advanced casting and homogenising technology from global leaders Wagstaff (USA) and Herwich (Austria).

Additionally, a new 1,20,000 tonnes a year primary foundry alloy (PFA) facility has been set up at the site, further expanding the company’s PFA production capabilities.

Rajiv Kumar, CEO, Vedanta Aluminium, said, “This scale-up enhances our ability to serve high-growth industries and reinforces India’s position as a rising force in the global aluminium landscape. We remain focused on delivering long-term value for the nation and all our stakeholders.”

C Chandru, CEO, Vedanta Jharsuguda, said, “This is a testament to our focus on expanding value-added aluminium production with speed, technical excellence and adherence to global standards.”

Ensure accountability of seed companies in Bill: MP

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Demanding that the proposed Seeds Bill be sent to the Parliamentary Standing Committee, former Agriculture Minister of Bihar and current Lok Sabha MP Sudhakar Singh suggested capping the price and accountability in the current draft. He, however, supported the need for a law saying the parliamentary panel has been insisting on it.

In an interaction with *businessline*, Singh, who is also a member of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Agriculture, said the Bill has to address some key issues like terminator seed technology, uncontrolled rates of seeds, accountability of seed companies and GMO technology. Explaining further, he



Lok Sabha MP Sudhakar Singh

said, “We should not use any terminator seed technology in the seed production system. Seed companies worldwide don’t aim to increase production, but to create a market for themselves by selling new seeds every year. This is why they want us to use genetically modified (GM) seeds and genome editing technology.”

He claimed that on the last 20 years of experience on Bt cotton, both the government and farmers have realised that allowing GM cotton was

a failed technology, and India has fallen into a trap.

But when asked if limiting the seed prices was not responsible for no new technologies coming to India, Singh said Bt cotton was introduced with the claim that there will be no pest attack. “But the PBW (pink bollworm) pest is infesting Bt cotton, and there is no cure for it,” he said.

LAW NEEDS REFORM

He also said that the trade agreement that has been reached with the US, allowing for zero duty import of cotton will again put India in a situation similar to 2000 when the country imported. “We never had a shortage of cotton. If needed in any particular year, we could have imported it from by waiving the import duty. So, what was the need to introduce failed technology?” he asked.

“The Seed Bill has been pending since 2004. It is introduced now because our committee raised questions about it. We want the law to clearly state that foreign technology will not be adopted. Only our hybrid and pure line technology should be adopted,” he said.

Singh further said there should be a maximum retail price for seeds. “Earlier, farmers used to exchange seeds among themselves. Now, companies are making huge profits, they modify seeds in the name of pest control, but this only results in more pests,” he said.

Stressing that the seeds law still needs reform, he said there is a need for seed insurance. “Companies selling seeds should guarantee production. If there is a loss of more than 10-20 per cent, compensation should be provided,” he said.

‘Chhattisgarh mustard yield can be raised by 70%

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Mustard production can be raised in the country by expanding areas in non-conventional States like Chhattisgarh, where the productivity can be raised by 70 per cent due to very low yield now. Also, a lot of rice fallow lands, which are left unown in winter, can be tapped with suitable planning.

Sharing his views on the potential of mustard crop in Chhattisgarh, P K Rai, former Director of ICAR’s Indian Institute of Rapeseed-Mustard Research, told *businessline* that transforming the rice fallows into productive farmland by adopting the rapeseed-mustard cultivation offers a remarkable opportunity to enhance farm income, improve crop



ping intensity, strengthen edible oil security, and promote sustainable agriculture.

RAISING YIELD

Rai, who is currently the Director of ICAR’s Raipur-based National Institute of Biotic Stress Management (NIBSM), said Chhattisgarh has a total cultivated area of 4.78 million hectares (mh), out of which the net irrigated area is 23 per cent. Paddy crop is grown in about 3.9 mh, mostly under rainfed conditions, across uplands and shallow lowlands.

Pointing out that nearly half of the rice area remains fallow in rabi season, he said that it throws a huge opportunity for mustard crop.

The current area under rapeseed-mustard in Chhattisgarh is very low — about 31,000 hectares with a production of 17,260 tonnes. There is scope to raise mustard productivity to 11-12 quintal per hectare from current 5-6 quintal per hectare, he said, adding the national average of yield was 14.63 quintal per hectare in 2024-25.

When asked why mustard in winter, Rai said it is a highly suitable crop among all rabi crops for rice fallow systems due to its adaptability, low water requirement, and short duration.

“Mustard can grow successfully with limited irrigation or even without irrigation under suitable moisture

conditions. Most varieties mature within 90-120 days, fitting well between rice harvest and before summer onset in the state. Besides, mustard can tolerate moderate drought and temperature variability,” he said.

He said that the sowing window from mid-November to first week of December coincides with cool and congenial winter temperatures ranging in the range of 25-30 degree Celsius, is ideal for the growth and development of mustard including toria. He also added that there is also a possibility of mixed-cropping with gram (chana).

India’s mustard production in 2024-25 had dropped to 12.67 million tonnes from 13.26 mt due to a fall in acreage. This year, there is marginal improvement in area 8.94 mh from 8.66 mh in 2024-25.

73% of MoUs signed since 2021 converted, 35% projects operational: Tamil Nadu CM

STRONG IMPLEMENTATION. Over 867 of the 1,179 MoUs signed in the last 5 years are in an advanced stage

Our Bureau
Chennai

Tamil Nadu achieved a conversion rate of 73.53 per cent of the memoranda of understanding (MoU) signed since 2021 when the DMK government returned to power in the State.

In the last five years, a total of 1,179 MoUs were signed, with a total investment commitment of ₹12.37 lakh crore, creating 36.52 lakh jobs. Of this, 867 projects are in advanced stages - 73.53 per cent conversion - and 35.11 per cent in operation, Chief Minister MK Stalin announced on Thursday at the 'Conversion Conclave 2026'.

SPEEDY ACTION

"This data is for all those who have been asking us questions about the conversion of the MoUs," he said.



Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin receiving a memento from Industries Minister TRB Rajaa. Chief Secretary N Muruganandam, Industries Secretary Arun Roy and Guidance Tamil Nadu MD Darez Ahmed are also present BUJOY GHOSH

The gap between the inauguration and the laying of the foundation stone of the Phoenix-Kothari Footwear Project in Perambalur was 12 months. The government signed an MoU with VinFast in January 2024, laid the foundation stone for the project the next month, and

launched it in August 2025. Similarly, work on the Tata-JLR project started in September 2024, and the car was unveiled this week. This was possible due to a single window and fast clearance, he said. Industries Minister TRB Rajaa said 18 investment

conclaves were held across the State and abroad, including in Chennai, Coimbatore, Thoothukudi, Dubai and the US.

In the conclaves, a total of 1,130 MoUs were signed with a committed investment of ₹10.43 lakh crore and a committed employment of 33.30 lakh persons.

On conversion from the foreign conclaves the Chief Minister visited, Rajaa said the conversion was 69.56 per cent, with 26.08 per cent operational and 48 out of the 69 MoUs signed being in the advanced stage, he said.

On the economic investment, Rajaa said the economic impact of the investments have been that the State achieved 11.19 per cent GSDP growth in FY25; 9.38 per cent growth 4-years in manufacturing average; 36 per cent growth in electronics exports in five years; 36 per cent growth in per capita

income in four years; \$52.07 billion (2x growth in exports in a year) and 14.74 per cent manufacturing growth in one year.

The focus in the last five years was on jobs, not just investment numbers, with 36.52 lakh jobs created via the MoUs. As per EPFO, additions since 2021 were 29.63 lakh. "We are corroborating the State's data with that of the Central government data," he said.

On Thursday, the State government signed an MoU with Bharat Biotech for a bio-similars manufacturing in Kancheepuram district at an investment of ₹5,000 crore and providing employment for 5,000 persons.

An MoU was also signed with Hyundai Motors India Foundation for setting up a skill development centre at Kancheepuram for training 7,000 students in futuristic skills.

Dabur to invest ₹400 crore in Tamil Nadu manufacturing facility

Our Bureau
Chennai



Dabur India CEO Mohit Malhotra BUJOY GHOSH

Dabur India Ltd, the world's largest Ayurvedic company, will invest ₹400 crore to set up a manufacturing facility in Tindivanam, Tamil Nadu.

This will be the company's first manufacturing plant in south India. On Thursday, Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin virtually performed the ground breaking ceremony for the unit to come up about 130 km south of Chennai.

JOB CREATION

The facility has the potential to generate over 250 direct jobs, besides creating thousands of indirect opportunit-

ies, and contribute towards building future-ready skills amongst local communities in and around the plant, a statement said.

Dabur India Chief Executive Officer Mohit Malhotra said, "This ground-breaking is a defining step in building

Dabur's next chapter, with manufacturing that is faster, smarter, greener and closer to the consumer. Tamil Nadu gives us the platform to scale with agility and serve south India with greater speed and freshness."

In the initial phase, the plant will manufacture Dabur's range of toothpastes, such as Dabur Red Toothpaste and Meswak, in addition to personal care brands such as Dabur Gulabari, Vatika Hair Oil and Anmol Hair Oil.

Over time, the production will be expanded to include Real Juices, Amla Hair Oil and additional brands, positioning Tindivanam as a key pillar of Dabur's southern manufacturing network.

'Kolkata records 239% surge in GCC leasing in 2025'

Press Trust of India
Kolkata

Kolkata recorded a robust 239 per cent year-on-year growth in Global Capability Centre (GCC) leasing in 2025, a report said on Thursday.

According to the latest office market data from property consultant Cushman & Wakefield, GCC gross leasing volume in the city surged to 0.51 million square feet (msf) in 2025, compared to 0.15 msf in the previous year.

The sharp rise saw GCCs accounting for 30 per cent of Kolkata's total office leasing of 1.71 msf during the year, a significant jump from a 9 per cent share in 2024.

While the absolute scale of activity remains modest compared to pan-India figures, which hit a record high of 29.3 msf in 2025, the growth highlights improving market depth and talent-led demand in the city.

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M&M plans ₹196-crore expansion of Mahindra Research Valley

Our Bureau
Chennai

Mahindra & Mahindra Ltd. (M&M) will expand its Advanced Research and Development Centre and additional testing facilities at Mahindra Research Valley (MRV) in Chennai. It has committed an investment of ₹196 crore to augment MRV's capabilities to sup-

port advanced vehicle design, product engineering and technology developments.

The facility will be up and running within this calendar year, says a release.

JOB GENERATION

Once fully operational, the expanded facility is projected to create additional employment opportunities for around 2,000 professionals,

spanning engineering, research and associated technical roles.

R Velusamy, President, Automotive Business, said, "This expansion underscores our long-term commitment to advancing product engineering capabilities in India, enhancing global competitiveness, and leveraging cutting-edge technology to deliver superior products to customers worldwide."



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India-first careers gain ground amid visa delays and global volatility

STRUCTURAL SHIFT. Domestic opportunities signal a broader rebalancing of outward migration

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

A sharp drop in Indian students going abroad, coupled with rising visa uncertainty, is triggering a structural shift in talent mobility, with more early- and mid-career professionals opting for India-first careers as domestic opportunities expand, signalling a broader rebalancing of outward migration.

According to Indeed's Global Career Work & Mobility Report 2026, which surveyed 552 employers and 1,019 employees, around 61 per cent of Indian professionals now prefer global remote roles over physically relocating overseas.

Alongside, the Government of India's Bureau of Immigration data shared in Parliament show that Indians travelling abroad for education fell to 6.26 lakh in 2025, from 7.7 lakh in 2024 and 9.08 lakh in 2023.

"Friction in key destination markets is no longer just 'temporary paperwork'; candidates now treat it as a structural risk — higher rejection probability, longer processing, tighter scrutiny, and narrower post-study work outcomes. From our advisory conversations, more candidates are taking the India role first and keeping overseas as an option, rather than planning life around a single visa-dependent move," Varun Singh, MD, XIPHIAS Immigration, observed.

DIGITAL ROLES
The shift is not uniform across industries, with technology and digital roles being the most visibly affected since these sectors are highly compatible with remote work.

On the other hand, finance and consulting show a partial impact. While many global functions can operate from India, certain leadership and



SIGNIFICANT DROP. Indians travelling abroad for education fell to 6.26 lakh in 2025 from 7.70 lakh in 2024 and 9.08 lakh in 2023

front office roles still benefit from relocation.

Healthcare, academia and regulated professions remain less affected by the remote alternative since they require physical presence, licensing, or on-ground clinical and research engagement.

"The pivot toward domestic or remote global roles is strongest in digitally transferable industries, while physically dependent professions continue to rely on in-

ternational mobility," Ankit Mehra, Founder and CEO of GyanDhan, explained.

DOMESTIC HUBS
Many MNCs are embedding global teams in India, enabling professionals to manage international portfolios and lead cross-border projects from domestic hubs, with remote global roles further expanding access to international exposure without relocation.

While US and European

salaries remain higher in absolute terms, remote roles allow Indian professionals to tap global pay scales while benefiting from India's lower cost of living, narrowing the economic incentive to move abroad.

However, this temporary correction may be a structural rebalancing rather than a permanent reversal.

RISK TOLERANCE
"The desire to go abroad has not disappeared. What has changed is the risk tolerance. Candidates now treat immigration outcomes as probabilistic. When that mindset changes, behaviour changes in durable ways: more Plan B thinking, more India-first moves, and more emphasis on roles that are resilient to policy swings. If immigration policies ease in major markets, there will likely be some rebound, but it will be selective, not a full return to the old pattern," Singh shared.

Air India to consider ₹88,000 crore FY27 budget with bulk as opex outlay

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

The board of Tata Group-owned Air India is expected to meet on Friday (February 13, 2026) to consider a budget of around ₹88,000 crore for financial year 2026-27 (FY27), with the bulk of the outlay earmarked for operational expenditure, top sources in the airline told *businessline*.

When contacted, Air India did not respond to *businessline*'s queries.

Sources told *businessline* that the upcoming board meeting assumes significance as the airline is expected to present a new plan to achieve profitability.

Notably, they said the airline might move away from its previous plan referred to as "Road to Profitability".

According to sources, the airline is projecting revenues in the range of ₹75,000-80,000 crore for the next fiscal. Consequently, the potential shortfall of around ₹8,000-10,000 crore may be supported by promoter Tata Sons, as per sources familiar



with the matter. Besides, sources pointed out that hiring in select operational and engineering roles, as well as rationalisation of international operations in view of persistent airspace restrictions will be other items on the board's agenda.

'BLACK SWAN' EVENTS
The airline has suffered the impact of a series of "black swan" events over the past one year, including geopolitical tensions, airspace closures, safety-related disruptions and operational challenges.

A case in point, sources cited, is the impact of Pakistan's airspace closure, which on a full-year basis would cost the airline approximately ₹4,500-₹5,000

crore on account of longer flight routings and higher fuel burn.

"Now even Iran airspace is closed, impacting operations to Europe and to the US. The longer routes are more time-consuming and expensive to operate," a second source said.

"International route rationalisation might be discussed. However, the cost-cutting measures will most probably consume the majority of the board's focus," the source noted. Presently, the airline is trying to boost cost saving measures; it has frozen fresh hirings and placed certain travel restrictions on executives.

Last year, Air India undertook temporary reductions in some international and domestic services to stabilise operations and manage disruptions, including safety inspections and extended flight routings.

Meanwhile, delays in aircraft deliveries, ongoing fleet refurbishment, and integration-related costs continue to exert pressure on finances and capacity expansion plans.

AC sales see strong uptick in Jan

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

After a washout summer season in 2025 due to unseasonal rain, consumer durable makers are gearing up for a stronger summer season.

Players said they have begun witnessing an uptick in demand for air-conditioners from January with sell-out growth in double-digits.

Players anticipate the upcoming summer season to shape up strongly for the AC category.

Sanjay Chitkara, Director & Co, Chief Sales & Marketing Officer, LG Electronics

India, told *businessline* that as per early indicators, January performance shaped to be better than last year.

"We expect Q4 to be a strong quarter. Our trade partners have gone through a period of inventory adjustment during Q3, so inventory levels are at healthy levels. Demand visibility has improved, and we have witnessed double-digit growth in sell-out in January for air-conditioners among other categories," said Chitkara.

STAR RATING NORMS
With the implementation of new energy BEE star rating norms from January 1, trade partners are also in the pro-

cess of liquidating inventory of old star-rated models while stocking up on new models aligned to the updated norms.

The AC market is pegged at about 11-12 million units in India, and expected to grow at 15 per cent CAGR in the coming years.

Abhishek Verma, Head, Product Marketing & Planning, Panasonic HVAC and CC India, said: "In the span of the first 45 days of the year, our sell-out has shown a growth of roughly about 40 per cent for AC products. We are witnessing signs of early onset of summer looking at trends in South India which is encouraging."

Airlines flag 'operational instability' over crew rest norms

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

The airline industry has formally raised objections to the Directorate General of Civil Aviation's (DGCA) latest draft regulations on cabin crew fatigue management norms.

In a letter dated January 12, 2026, addressed to the DGCA, the Federation of Indian Airlines (FAI), which represents major carriers including Air India, IndiGo and SpiceJet, stated that the proposed framework could create structural constraints across the sector.

businessline has reviewed

the FIA letter which cautioned that the proposed framework could lead to operational instability.

Notably, the federation described the draft rules as more restrictive than prevailing international standards.

According to the FIA, the proposed norms lack the required flexibility to address diverse operational models followed by Indian carriers.

SCHEDULING ISSUE
On the issue of scheduling, the FIA has urged the regulator to adopt 'Flight Duty Period' which is defined as the total duration a crew member remains on duty as



the primary metric for assessing fatigue, instead of daily flight time caps.

Besides, the federation has raised objections to the proposed expansion of the "night window" between midnight and 6am, along with a restriction limiting crew to two landings during this period.

As per the federation,

these measures would disrupt established crew pairings and result in additional duty days.

Furthermore, the draft provision which mandates single-room accommodation for cabin crew during layovers has emerged as another area of disagreement.

FIA has termed the requirement as operationally impractical, citing limited hotel inventory. Nevertheless, it maintained that twin-sharing arrangements allow quicker assistance in the event of medical emergencies.

Additionally, the federation stated that the cumulative impact of the proposed

provisions would lead to increased duty fragmentation and a higher number of nights spent away from home base.

It added that the changes could reduce airlines' ability to recover from disruptions arising from adverse weather conditions or technical issues.

The industry's representation comes after a period of operational disruptions in late 2025 due to the implementation of the new pilot fatigue regulations.

Accordingly, the Federation of Indian Airlines has sought a phased or staggered implementation of the proposed cabin crew rules.



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